

The Development of an Issue Public: Evidence from The Eras Tour*

Short Title: The Development of an Issue Public

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Abstract

Scholars describe the American electorate as generally uninformed about politics, but segmented into “issue publics” with structured preferences on specific issues. These groups may ameliorate the democratic dilemma, but theory and evidence on how individuals join them lag behind that ambitious claim. We propose a two-stage theory of issue public development. It begins with *potential issue publics*—groups with highly-valued interests or identities that hold latent connections to political issues. A pivotal circumstance then activates an issue’s political relevance for individual members. We test this theory with an instructive case: Taylor Swift fans’ attempts to purchase high-demand concert tickets in November 2022. Website errors created as-if random ticket allocation, personalizing the politics of economic fairness for unlucky fans. Survey evidence supports our preregistered expectations: fans’ ticket-buying fates caused noteworthy attitudinal and behavioral differences toward event ticketing politics. We conclude that highlighting the unrealized political relevance of interests could facilitate democratic accountability.

Keywords: Issue publics; Economic attitudes; Political engagement; Democratic dilemma; Natural experiments; Swifties

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1 Introduction

Do personal connections to political issues structure attitudes and behavior? Groups of individuals whose backgrounds or experiences motivate them to pay close attention to specific issues, or “issue publics,” have been studied for decades by scholars of American politics since Converse (1964). Issue publics represent an important contrast from the typical image of an uninformed, disengaged mass public because members’ opinions on their issues of interest are well-structured and durable. Thus, they have been proposed as a solution to the “democratic dilemma,” which holds that citizens may be incapable of making informed decisions despite their responsibility to do so (Lupia and McCubbins 1998). If Americans are well-informed on the select issue(s) that they are passionate about, decisionmaking from their informed attitudes can ultimately reinforce democratic accountability (Gilens 2020).

However, most extant research investigates issue publics *after* they have developed. Scholars have asked whether and what kind of issue publics exist (Krosnick 1990; Henderson 2014; Ryan and Ehlinger 2023), finding evidence for numerous examples across time and issues. Others have studied how these existing issue publics behave (Bolsen and Leeper 2013; Anand and Krosnick 2003) and coordinate (Sides and Karch 2008; Kim 2009). Researchers also suggest that issue public membership is a key component of democratic participation (see Leeper and Robison 2020). Yet this focus on existing issue publics leaves open questions about the individual-level roots of issue public membership and whether their development can induce responsiveness from politicians. We contribute to this less-investigated, but critical, area of issue publics research. We ask, how do members move from recognizing no personal stake in the issue’s politics to caring deeply enough for it to shape their political attitudes and behavior?

To answer this question, we propose a two-stage theory to explain the process by which individuals join issue publics. The first stage is membership in a *potential issue public*: a group of people who hold a highly-valued interest, identity, and/or value with a *latent* connection to a political issue. Importantly, members of the potential issue public do not consider themselves affected by the issue’s politics at this stage. However, due to the pre-existing importance of the interest or identity

which defines potential issue public membership, the issue’s political significance is susceptible to activation from an incident, event, or other consequential experience. Such pivotal circumstances constitute the second stage of our theory. Potential issue public members become more likely to join the issue public when a significant situation reveals the issue’s relevance to their self-interest or group identification and begins influencing their attitudes and behavior. While the latent concern for the issue exists in all potential issue public members, the issue must become politically relevant *at the individual level* to precipitate joining the issue public itself.

We test our theory by analyzing a specific case that is substantively relevant and informative for understanding issue public development more generally. Our evidence comes from a natural experiment involving fans of American singer-songwriter Taylor Swift—better known as “Swifties”—who constitute a potential issue public in our framework. Swifties are cohesive, strongly devoted, and hold a long-term interest in the politics of the event ticket industry. However, this connection between event ticketing politics and their deeply-held fanship was latent until the group attempted to purchase tickets to “Taylor Swift | The Eras Tour” in November 2022. Lotteries determining sale access and errors with ticket vendor Ticketmaster’s web platform created as-if random allocation of primary-market tickets. For the unlucky Swifties, this incident dramatically personalized the politics of the event ticket industry—an example of economic fairness concerns that affect American consumers, encompassing problems associated with lack of market competition and inequality.

Using an original survey of over 4,000 Swifties fielded August-September 2023—shortly after the first leg of the tour concluded and nine months after the pivotal November 2022 ticket sale—we test our preregistered expectations that fans who were exogenously denied access to primary-market tickets developed notably different attitudes about and heightened political engagement regarding event ticketing. We find substantial empirical support. Unlucky Swifties were more likely to discuss political dimensions of event ticketing and agree that Ticketmaster’s lack of competition and unequal ticket distribution processes were problematic. Sale failure also increased fans’ likelihood of filing a complaint with the Federal Trade Commission (FTC), reflecting an important action citizens can take to spur policy change. Moreover, descriptive evidence suggests that government responded to

this situation with tangible action. However, while the episode likely led to substantial development of the “event ticket issue public,” its effects did not extend to the development of broader issue publics pertaining to monopolies and inequality in general (Ryan and Ehlinger 2023). Thus, we ultimately conclude that issue publics *can* facilitate a more responsible, engaged polity. But the inherent specificity of the issues that galvanize issue public members’ engagement could limit the concept as a major solution to the democratic dilemma.

2 Issue Publics and the Democratic Dilemma

The starting point in the study of issue publics is Converse’s (1964) seminal article, which is best known for demonstrating a general lack of stability and constraint in the American public’s ideological and policy preferences. A final section introduces issue publics as a counterbalance to the article’s main thesis. Converse explains that individuals’ opinions on topics of personal significance exhibit meaningful structure (52–53). He also finds that citizens who belong to *multiple* issue publics uniquely show constraint that resembles that of elites (candidates for Congress). Most importantly, his conceptualization of issue public membership is based solely in attitudes; he argues that issue public members hold stabilized preferences on the issue in question.

Ryan and Ehlinger (2023, 14–15) offer three criteria that provide useful extensions to Converse’s (1964) baseline description. First, issue publics represent an *affective orientation*. Their members have an “emotionally charged psychological investment” in the political issue that separates them from someone who is simply highly attentive to politics and thus cares about essentially all issues. Second, issue public members’ interest in their issue is *long-standing*, meaning they pay attention to the issue even when it is not salient to the general public. Finally, membership in the issue public *affects political judgments*—it shapes attitudes and behaviors related to politics. This last criterion connects the issue public to meaningful political engagement that lays the foundation for democratic accountability.

Subsequent work has made important advancements in scholarly understanding of issue publics. The American public is comprised of many issue publics and most people only belong to a small number (Krosnick 1990). Issue public members hold distinct and stronger preferences on their

issues compared to the general public (Claassen and Nicholson 2013). They also self-select into news exposure on those issues (Bolsen and Leeper 2013), seek more and better information about them compared to non-members (Kim 2009; Henderson 2014), and retain that knowledge across elections (Henderson 2014). Moreover, research connects issue publics' preferences to behavior. Members evaluate candidates based on their issues (Anand and Krosnick 2003) and issue-specific campaign appeals may mobilize them under some circumstances (Sides and Karch 2008). Issue public membership can also influence vote choice in some contexts (cf. Kim 2009; Dufresne and Ouellet 2021).

But despite considerable progress, several unanswered questions remain. From a theoretical perspective, scholars have not established key elements of issue public development, such as precisely how individuals become members. Methodologically, measuring issue publics has long been a challenge in empirical research. One common approach uses survey respondents' stated issue priorities through closed-ended (Krosnick 1990; Wojcieszak 2014) or—preferably—open-ended questions (Ryan and Ehlinger 2023). These methods are intuitive and practical, allowing for the study of multiple issue publics at once. But a research design that simultaneously measures which issues people care about and how those issues influence their political attitudes and behavior risks endogeneity (Leeper and Robison 2020) and/or confounding from other factors such as elite cues (Lenz 2012).

Accordingly, another option involves an “interest imputation” assumption that particular issue publics correspond with individual characteristics (e.g., Hutchings 2003; Bolsen and Leeper 2013; Claassen and Nicholson 2013; Henderson 2014). For instance, Sides and Karch (2008) group senior citizens (entitlement programs), military veterans (veterans' benefits), and parents (education and childcare) into issue publics *ex ante*. This approach trades endogeneity for a risk of false positives and false negatives. Many senior citizens undoubtedly consider that identity to be politically meaningful and connect it to entitlement program policy—but not all of them (Campbell 2003). And others who are not seniors may be politically motivated in anticipation of receiving benefits and/or because they are caretakers of senior citizens. Thus, simply analyzing survey respondents

over an age threshold may yield a biased account of the entitlement program issue public.

2.1 Democratic Performance

Better understanding the development of issue publics is crucial because they form a potentially important link in the chain of democratic accountability. The presence of issue publics means that at least some citizens are attentive to an issue (even if the mass public is not), which creates incentive for government to respond to citizen preferences. Issue publics can motivate citizens who lack conventional participatory resources to take political action (Han 2009). Thus, in the right context issue publics can serve as an important connecting mechanism between citizens and politicians (e.g., Krosnick 1990; Hutchings 2003). Leeper and Robison (2020, 240) refer to issue publics as “the backbone of democratic politics” (although their own empirical investigation qualifies this statement). Elliott (2020) conceives of issue publics as “deliberative enclaves” that improve democratic decisionmaking by efficiently dividing cognitive labor, concentrating dispersed information, and enhancing the quality of members’ issue-specific preferences (396). Gilens (2020, 47) states that if issue public members use their issues to guide their political engagement, aggregation will lead the electorate to fulfill its democratic role (see also Dufresne and Ouellet 2021, 281–283; Ryan and Ehlinger 2023, 13–14). In short, the combination of many issue publics across society could help solve the democratic dilemma (Lupia and McCubbins 1998).

However, an alternative perspective challenges and adds nuance to this optimistic viewpoint. Somin (2016, 122–124) offers several reasons for skepticism regarding issue publics’ benefits to democratic performance. Most critically, he notes that issue specialization may simply devolve into policy capture by unrepresentative organized interests, promoting rent-seeking and hindering accountability to the public. But Elliott (2020, 394–395) draws attention to heterogeneity *within* issue publics, which provides a compelling counter to this critique. Issue public members are not constrained to hold the same policy views on their issue (Elliott 2020, 388). Indeed, part of their strength as enclaves for deliberation is that subgroups within them can represent different opinions or perspectives. This trait distinguishes issue publics from groups that are mobilized by issue organizers in support of one particular side of a debate (Han 2016; Han et al. 2021; Ganz 2024).

Somin (2016) also questions whether individuals can define an issue with enough precision to facilitate responsiveness from politicians. Groups may be affected by an issue, but lack the ability to identify that relationship and/or connect it to public policies. Organization and mobilization often plays an important role in drawing such connections for people (Han 2016; Han et al. 2021; Ganz 2024). However, our theory and research design consider the possibility that critical events or situations could also form these links for individuals without direct influence from issue organizations. Moreover, our empirical analyses test whether individuals perceive this connection in narrow, specific terms or if they can generalize it to related issues. The answer to that question holds implications for understanding issue publics' capacity to mitigate the democratic dilemma.

3 Two Stages of Issue Public Membership

We propose a two-stage framework for the process of how citizens join an issue public. While there are likely many reasons a person might join, one pathway that stands out in the literature is personal significance tied to the politics of an issue. As Krosnick (1990, 72–73) explains, this personal significance may stem from a connection between the issue and material self-interest. Other sources include identification with a group that considers the issue important and direct relevance to individuals' social and personal values.¹ Our theory is inclusive of all of these forms of personal significance. However, past work also invokes personal importance as both a cause and a marker of issue public membership. This perspective raises the endogeneity concerns mentioned above and leaves open the question of how individuals begin to consider an issue personally significant. Our framework addresses this problem by identifying one key way the personal significance of political issues emerges and explaining how it transforms into issue public membership.

It is important to note that while our theory shares similarities with the literature on organizing

¹Group identity can play a key role in animating our theory if it is closely associated with the perception that “an attitude object is likely to have clear and direct impact upon [an individual’s] rights, privileges, or lifestyle” (Krosnick 1990, 72–73). However, we contend that individuals can still experience our proposed stages of issue public membership in isolation, so group identity is not a strict requirement of the theory.

(e.g., Han 2009, 2016; Han et al. 2021; Ganz 2024), several features of issue publics indicate that joining them is conceptually distinct from becoming organized, warranting our theoretical framework. First, issue public membership can occur independently from action by an organization or activist. Second, the same pivotal circumstance could lead two individuals to join the same issue public, but take on opposite perspectives. In contrast, motivation from organizing is typically tied to one side of an issue. Next, joining an issue public suggests larger variation in the member's expected political actions, from high to low engagement. Becoming organized implies comparatively less of the low engagement response.

3.1 The Potential Issue Public

How does the personal significance of a political issue emerge? We critically take a step back to before the politics of an issue affect an individual directly—and thus before they are distinguishable from other members of the mass public with respect to intensity of preferences and issue engagement. The first step of our theory pertains to the interests, identities, and/or values that citizens consider most important to their lives (Krosnick 1990). If one of these highly-valued characteristics connects to a political issue, but the person does not discern that connection, we deem their political concern about the issue *latent*, or hidden (Truman 1951; Key 1961; Ryan and Ehlinger 2023). Those citizens with a latent interest in a political issue based in their interests, identities, and/or values comprise a potential issue public.² They hold the hidden potential to satisfy the first criterion in Ryan and Ehlinger's (2023) definition of an issue public—a unique affective attachment to the issue. But at this point, the issue does not affect their political attitudes or behavior any more or less than it affects the average citizen.

For example, Sides and Karch (2008) identify parents as an issue public for education and childcare issues. We revise this claim by arguing that all parents are not intrinsically members

²We use the terms “latent” and “potential” issue public differently than past literature on interest groups, which defines a potential interest group as holding a *realized* political interest that is latent because the group is unorganized (Truman 1951). We define a potential issue public as a group (whether organized or unorganized) that holds an *unrealized* potential to form a political interest.

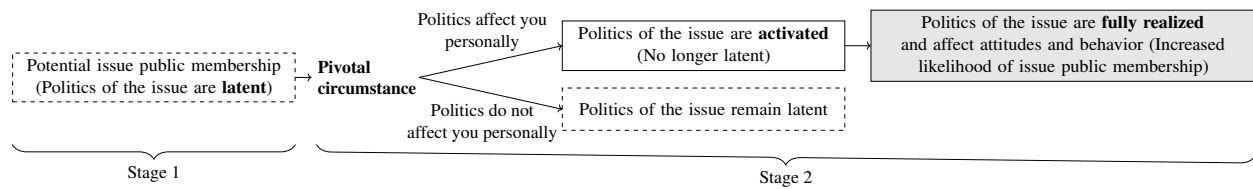
of such a broad political group. Instead, we propose that parents are *potential* members of more *specific* issue publics. While all parents permanently value their role as “parent” and hold a deep interest in their children’s welfare, we contend that potential issue public membership stemming from this role depends on the major aspects of a child’s life at that particular point in time. In doing so, we challenge the traditional conceptualization of issue public interests and members as broadly-defined (e.g., that *all* education and childcare issues are of interest to *all* parents). Instead, we align with and emphasize the highly-specific nature of issue publics apparent in recent work (Ryan and Ehlinger 2023). Indeed, the potential issue public is a key theoretical innovation because it precisely defines which members of the mass public are most likely to hold the internal motivation to understand the problem and seek political solutions if they move into the issue public. This specific targeting of primed individuals counters Somin’s (2016) critique that issue public members cannot identify which policies would connect to their issue (123). We contend that, when viewed narrowly, issue public members are up to this task.

Consider parents of a newborn who have chosen to use infant formula. These parents are more concerned with feeding their child compared to education policy and would likely consider that interest apolitical. However, feeding an infant is nonetheless connected to politics. Formula availability has long been vulnerable due to the consolidation of production to just a few companies and in 2022 it was impacted by ongoing regulatory and supply chain issues due to the COVID-19 pandemic. But as long as formula access is easy, the politics of its distribution are less concerning and likely hidden from these parents, despite the importance of procuring formula to their daily lives. New parents under these normal circumstances represent our conceptualization of a potential issue public, which is visualized in Figure 1. Then, the next step in our theory considers what happens to them when a pivotal circumstance—such as the infant formula shortage of 2022—creates a sudden and consequential change that reveals the politics of the issue.

3.2 Political Activation

The second stage of our framework explains how people move into the issue public from the potential issue public. We argue that an individual’s probability of joining an issue public increases

Figure 1: Two Stages of Issue Public Membership



when the once-latent connection of their highly-valued interest or identity to a political issue is activated (see Ryan and Ehlinger 2023, 54). As shown in Figure 1, a *pivotal circumstance* is a decisive point in time or set of conditions in which the politics of the issue directly affect a potential issue public member in a personally meaningful way.³ That is, the event triggers the emergence of the previously-hidden political connection to the individual’s interests, identity, and/or values. From that point, they outwardly display their latent motivation to understand the politics of the problem and seek political solutions. For formula-feeding parents, the shortage was a pivotal circumstance. The political nature of formula availability—which was always present, but latent—suddenly brought about extreme changes in their daily lives. The search for formula was an all-encompassing activity that affected maternal mental health and families’ finances as prices spiked.

In our theoretical framework, pivotal circumstances like the formula shortage are ultimately responsible for political activation. Without them, the potential issue public member’s latent connection to the issue’s politics is not revealed. However, the timing of this process may vary based on the nature of the circumstance, issue complexity, or other factors. As Figure 1 suggests, issue public membership could occur soon after activation or may involve realization over time.

The formula shortage was a circumstance that surfaced the politics of formula availability to the potential issue public’s members because of their pre-existing interest and identity as parents of a

³This concept is broadly similar to “disturbances” in the interest group literature (Truman 1951), “focusing events” in the agenda-setting literature (Kingdon 1995), and “critical junctures” in the study of comparative political institutions (Capoccia 2015). It could arise in several ways, including through discrete events, circumstances unique to an individual, or even messaging from social networks or elite politicians (Hutchings 2003; Henderson 2014).

newborn. According to our theory, formula-feeding parents affected by the politics of the shortage were much more likely to move from the potential issue public to the realized issue public compared to other, similarly-situated parents—such as those with children who transitioned to solid foods just before the shortage. But they likely did not affect, for instance, parents of children in a public school system. Their concerns focus on their children’s education, not infant formula. Political activation for this second group would likely occur when a pivotal circumstance connected their values and interests in the context of the politics of public school curricula.

For example, around the time the formula shortage was activating politics for new parents, the topics, terms, and books that public schools used for instruction—especially with respect to race and social justice—suddenly emerged for parents of school-aged children. The pivotal circumstance in this case was the May 2020 murder of George Floyd in Minneapolis and ensuing public debates over the state of race in American society (Clark 2023). Many parents suddenly confronted their values and interests with regard to this topic in the context of educational content in schools. And importantly, not all of them agreed. This divergence highlights a key point about the second stage in our theory: the pivotal circumstance does not necessarily activate the same viewpoint in individuals who move into the issue public (see Elliott 2020, 388). Our theoretical process can work similarly even for two potential issue public members who ultimately disagree on the politics of the issue.

In short, defining a potential issue public requires delineation of the pre-existing potential for an issue to have personal significance to potential issue public members. Then, political relevance can be activated in different ways. The lack of availability of a critical resource differs from prominent national attention to social justice, but both can signal previously-hidden connections to politics. It is important to identify the specific point of activation to explain individual-level movement into the realized issue public. Under our theory, not all members of a potential issue public are politically activated. Clarity with respect to both stages of the theory avoids incorrectly considering that, for example, *all* parents are equally likely to join either of these issue publics and/or that non-parents could never join them. This perspective ultimately yields smaller, more particularistic issue publics than considered in past literature.

3.3 Hypotheses

Our theoretical framework focuses on one important means by which citizens join issue publics: the newly-realized connection of politics to an individual's interests or identity. Our hypotheses posit attitudinal and behavioral differences between those for whom the politics of the issue are activated or not—the second stage in our theory. We focus on *divergence* in attitudes and behaviors because it is a common approach in the issue publics literature (e.g., Wojcieszak 2014; Ryan and Ehlinger 2023) and because it is important to understanding issue engagement more generally (Krupnikov and Levine 2019). See Section 5.2 for descriptions and justifications of the specific attitudes and behaviors we study.

H1 Within a potential issue public, issue attitudes among those for whom the politics of the issue are activated diverge from the issue attitudes of those for whom the politics are not activated.

H2 Within a potential issue public, political behaviors among those for whom the politics of the issue are activated diverge from the political behaviors of those for whom the politics are not activated.

Our potential issue public examples above are useful as illustrations of our theory's logic, but they lack exogenous variation in political activation among potential issue public members, which is crucial to testing these hypotheses. Accordingly, we turn next to an empirical setting that we argue included this necessary component of the research design.

4 Empirical Setting: “The Great War”

On November 1, 2022, Taylor Swift announced “Taylor Swift | The Eras Tour,” a long-awaited concert tour and her first since 2018. Immediately following this announcement, members of her massive and highly-devoted fanbase began eagerly applying for “Verified Fan” status with Ticketmaster, the primary-market vendor for ticket sales in the U.S. Swifties randomly selected for Verified Fan status would have access to one of 52 tour-date specific presales for the first U.S. leg of the tour held on November 15, 2022; all others would be “waitlisted” with no chance to purchase tickets during the presales. This event soon became infamously known as “The Great War” (a reference to a track title on the *3am Edition* of Swift's 2022 album *Midnights*). Although it

was a random process, the Verified Fan lottery was *perceived* as unfair. Bots and scalpers received the “Verified Fan” label while many Swifties who viewed themselves as true fans (and for whom the Verified Fan presales were marketed to serve) were placed on the waitlist.⁴ Then, those who were not already heartbroken from being waitlisted faced a drawn-out, error-prone, and emotional ticket-buying process.⁵ The underlying problem was that Ticketmaster expected between 1 and 2 million fans to access their website for the presales, but instead received 3.5 *billion* total requests during that time (Fruits et al. 2024). Ultimately, only some who attempted to purchase presale tickets—about 65% of those who were not already waitlisted, according to the data we describe below—were successful.

The ticket presale problems led Ticketmaster to cancel its public sale planned for November 18, which permanently spiked ticket prices on the secondary market.⁶ This decision devastated Swifties on the unlucky side of the presales, many of whom could only afford primary-market pricing (which was quite expensive on its own).⁷ Some made hard financial choices to save for

⁴As an example of how a seemingly neutral lottery system was viewed as unfair, consider the following reaction from a respondent to our survey (described below). “I think the most unfair part of the whole situation is that the verified codes were promised to go to fans so fans would get tickets and every time there was a ticket drop thousands of tickets instantly showed up on resale sites for multiple times the face value price. . . .”

⁵The emotional stakes of the event underscored Swifties’ strong, pre-existing group identity and self-interest in seeing a show. A respondent to our survey succinctly represented the emotions of many, noting “I cried, I screamed, I had major anxiety, I called my sister to have her calm me down. . . .”

⁶In May 2023, secondary-market tickets were, on average, 7-11 times more expensive in 2023 dollars than the average resale prices from Swift’s previous tours (TicketIQ 2023).

⁷“Face-value” tickets ranged from \$49 to \$499 before fees, and many of the best seats required the purchase of merchandise packages that added hundreds of dollars to the total cost. Ticketmaster also employed “dynamic pricing” which alters ticket prices based on current demand. Due to this variability, we focus on whether tickets were purchased from a primary-market vendor rather than

secondary-market tickets. Thousands who could not obtain tickets elected to “watch” the shows from outside the stadiums. And through social media, these fans witnessed other Swifties with more resources purchase tickets beyond those obtained from Ticketmaster and attend multiple tour stops, creating a clear division between “haves” and “have-nots” in the fanbase. Many voiced considerable frustration that Ticketmaster—which lacks a true competitor in the U.S.—or even Taylor Swift herself could have done more to improve the situation.

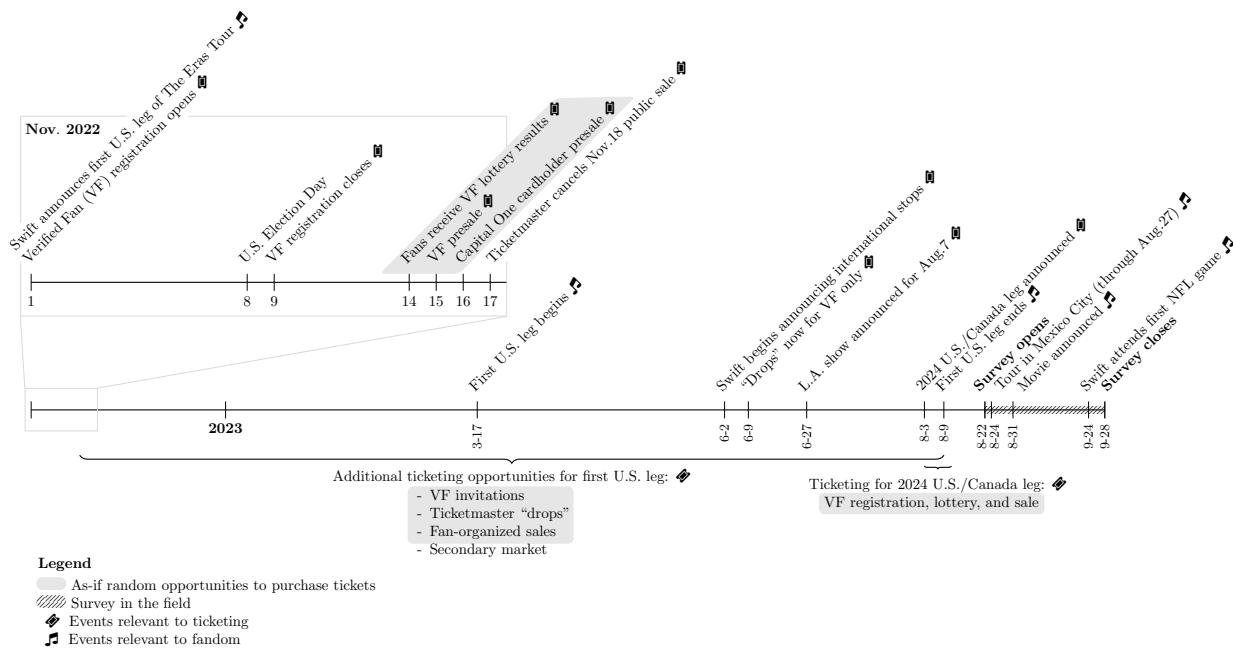
Concerns over this industry in the U.S. date back several decades as part of a constellation of issues related to economic fairness, such as consumers’ rights and inequality. The event ticket issue public did not originate with Swifties. Its roots can be traced back at least to the mid-1990s when grunge band Pearl Jam (and its fans) attempted to force Ticketmaster to lower service fees with an antitrust lawsuit, testimony before Congress, and a boycott (Boehlert 1995).⁸ Later, a 2010 merger with event promoter Live Nation renewed skepticism over the company’s ability to provide reliable service without competition. And since then, controversies and disputes with a range of artists have kept the issue public alive, even as millions of fans have purchased tickets from the company.

4.1 Identification

This case includes a clearly-defined potential issue public: Swifties who attempted to purchase tickets to The Eras Tour. These Swifties had the potential for political activation of a latent interest in event ticketing politics because of (1) their strong interest in securing tickets to The Eras Tour and future concerts, and (2) for many (but not necessarily all) of these ticket-seekers, a deep importance of their Swiftie group identity. We operationalize this potential issue public as Swifties who registered for Verified Fan status for the November 15, 2022 presales. Then, some members of that potential issue public directly, personally, and as-if randomly confronted the incident’s political implications by failing to secure tickets. This randomness created a control group of those who were successful in securing primary-market tickets and a treatment group of Swifties who were not. Importantly, the harsh reality of Ticketmaster’s near-monopoly became immediately and painfully evident to the ticket-less Swifties, who were forced to cope with Ticketmaster giving them no their specific price.

⁸See Section A13 of the appendix for details on the origins of the event ticket issue public.

Figure 2: Timeline of As-if Random Ticket-Buying Opportunities and Survey Data Collection



Note: The figure displays key events to our case. Events relevant to obtaining a ticket are denoted with a ticket emoji. Events shaded in light gray visualize as-if random opportunities to purchase tickets. Events relevant to the fandom, particularly while the survey was in the field (shaded in dark gray), are denoted with musical notes.

opportunity to see Swift live via primary-market purchase. Thus, both stages of our theoretical framework are represented.

Figure 2 provides a timeline of key events, including those related to ticketing and fandom. It denotes the exogenous sources of variation in the ticket-buying process with light gray shaded text. The first major source of variation occurred *before* the presales. Verified Fan status, required to access the ticket-buying platform on November 15, was allocated randomly via lottery (Ticketmaster 2023).⁹ Swifties had to register to become a Verified Fan for a first-choice and second-choice tour stop between November 1 and 9. A subset of registrants were then randomly selected into Verified Fan status for one of their preferred tour dates, while everyone else was waitlisted. Ticketmaster alerted all registered fans of their Verified Fan or waitlisted status on November 14, and Verified Fans were provided codes to enter the specific presale for which they were randomly selected.

⁹Ticketmaster also held presales on November 16 exclusively for Capital One credit cardholders. These fans bypassed the preregistration lottery, but still encountered all of the as-if random problems with Ticketmaster's platform.

The second major source of exogenous variation in ticketing allocation occurred *during* the November 15 presales. Problems internal to Ticketmaster’s web platform occurred at all stages of the ticket-buying process so users had essentially no means of avoiding or manipulating them. First, Ticketmaster randomly assigned everyone a place in a virtual queue, with hours-long wait times, unavoidable page time-outs, and related errors due to high website traffic.¹⁰ If able to advance from the queue, many fans’ Verified Fan codes did not work when they attempted to view available tickets. Finally, if able to select seats, many experienced tickets disappearing from their online carts, rejections of their credit cards, or related errors. These issues were widespread, requiring Ticketmaster to temporarily pause the queue at one point and delay several presales by five hours in an apparent attempt to solve the problems. While some fans were lucky and moved through efficiently, the vast majority were significantly impeded or even completely shut out.

A third major source of exogenous variation in securing primary-market tickets emerged from additional purchasing opportunities *after* the presales, from December 2022 to August 2023. In December, Ticketmaster emailed a subset of Verified Fans who were unlucky in the presales with instructions for purchasing “second-chance” tickets. Additionally, despite its website saying all shows were sold out, Ticketmaster sporadically released primary-market tickets with no transparent timing or quantity in the days leading up to a tour stop, which fans dubbed ticket “drops.” Swifties also organized a system for fans to resell tickets at primary-market rates to other fans. Lastly, a second Verified Fan registration, lottery, and sale took place August 3-11, 2023 for a 2024 U.S. and Canada leg of the tour. These later opportunities did reflect some potentially systematic decisionmaking among Swifties who preregistered for Verified Fan status for the November 2022 presales. They could choose to pursue the additional routes (or not). However, all routes were still characterized by a high degree of actual and/or as-if randomization. Thus, we argue that the

¹⁰Fans who purchased tickets to the canceled 2020 “*Lover Fest*” tour and/or *Midnights* merchandise—both of which occurred before the tour announcement—received official notification that they would be “boosted” to a better virtual queue position. However, post-sale investigation indicated that this benefit was likely never implemented correctly (Palus and Fung 2022).

exogeneity of treatment assignment stayed in place for these later processes for our population of interest. Another option, of course, was the secondary market. Given the high cost of resale tickets, this decision was *not* credibly as-if random. We account for these post-November ticket-buying options in our empirical analyses described below.

Section A2 of the appendix contains a comprehensive justification of this empirical case as a natural experiment under Dunning’s (2012) framework. In brief, we provide detailed discussion of the qualitative evidence in favor of the as-if randomization and validity of the treatment. On the former, we contend that neither Swifties nor Ticketmaster possessed the information, incentives, *and* capacities to meaningfully manipulate treatment status. Additionally, we make the case that treatment (1) created a substantively meaningful difference between the two groups, (2) was highly relevant to the study of issue publics, and (3) was internally valid.

We also justify our design in light of a possible threat from treatment spillover (see Section A2.2.1). Swifties who secured primary-market tickets (i.e., the control group) likely also experienced some exposure to the politics of event ticketing through communication with other fans and/or the considerable media attention that the ticket sales received. Nonetheless, we contend that other factors counteracted this risk of spillover bias. First, ticketed events are inherently individualized. Group identity is a component of Swiftie fanship for many, but each fan was still required to possess their own personal ticket to gain access. Thus, treatment was specifically defined *by the ticketing process and at the individual level*. Further, simple awareness of the ticketing problem was not sufficient to treat an individual. The critical difference between Swifties was among those who experienced a show (which required a ticket) and those who did not. Our study analyzes the *most substantively meaningful contrast* of this case. Finally, any treatment spillover that did exist would reduce differences between treated and untreated Swifties, yielding a conservative test of our theory.

5 Research Design

To test our hypotheses, we administered an online survey to a sample of Swifties who registered for a Verified Fan code and tried to buy tickets *for themselves* during the November 2022 presales.¹¹

¹¹Appendix Section A1 discusses ethical considerations regarding this research.

We preregistered the design and hypotheses on August 21, 2023. The survey was in the field from August 22 to September 28 (see Figure 2). Because as-if random ticketing opportunities occurred from November 2022 to August 2023, we administered the survey after the first U.S. tour leg concluded to ensure we could fully assess treatment status and any noncompliance. We fielded our survey using a multifaceted sampling strategy designed to target the fanbase broadly.

First, we contracted with the survey firm YouGov to identify respondents in its U.S. panel who fit our population of interest. This effort yielded a sample of 789 Swifties. Additionally, we worked directly with prominent members of the fanbase to share the survey link in three locations popular in the Swiftie community on social media.¹² Figure 3 displays some examples of how these “elite” Swifties used their platforms to promote the survey, which included (1) their X/Twitter timelines ($n = 2,617$), (2) a livestream of the opening concerts of the international leg of the tour in Mexico City on a website called SwiftStream ($n = 562$), (3) the Taylor Swift subreddit *r/TaylorSwift* ($n = 208$), and (4) snowball sampling ($n = 59$).¹³ This targeted social media sampling yielded 3,446 usable cases. Together with the YouGov sample, our final sample contains 4,235 Swifties.¹⁴

5.1 Treatment Definitions

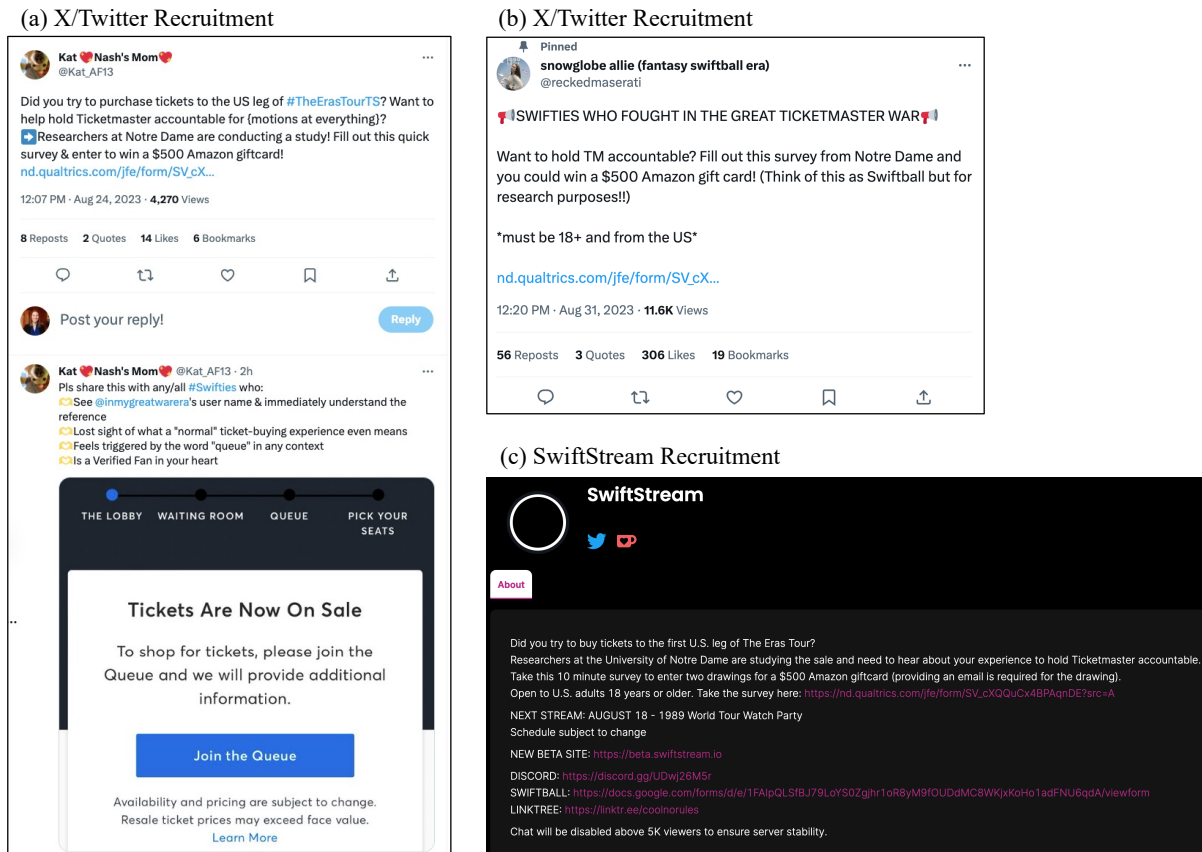
Consider the following description of the ticketing process from one Swiftie in our data:

¹²These Swifties and others like them rose to prominence in the fanbase because they responded to the Ticketmaster presales by organizing to assist other fans (e.g., coordinating face-value ticket sales, hosting livestreams). To our knowledge, they were not event ticketing activists prior to November 2022. Instead, they demonstrated the theoretical process we develop and test here. They began as members of the potential issue public, became attentive to the politics of event ticketing due to the Ticketmaster presales, and responded with coordinating action to help the Swiftie community.

¹³We deliberately imposed essentially no restrictions on recruitment messaging to maintain trust with these elite Swifties and the fanbase. In Section A6.2 of the appendix we show through analyzing the YouGov and social media samples separately that the elite Swifties’ messaging did not induce bias via priming effects.

¹⁴Appendix Section A3 provides more data collection details, descriptive information about the sample and variables analyzed, and evidence that respondents were engaged and attentive.

Figure 3: Examples of Messaging for Social Media Participant Recruitment

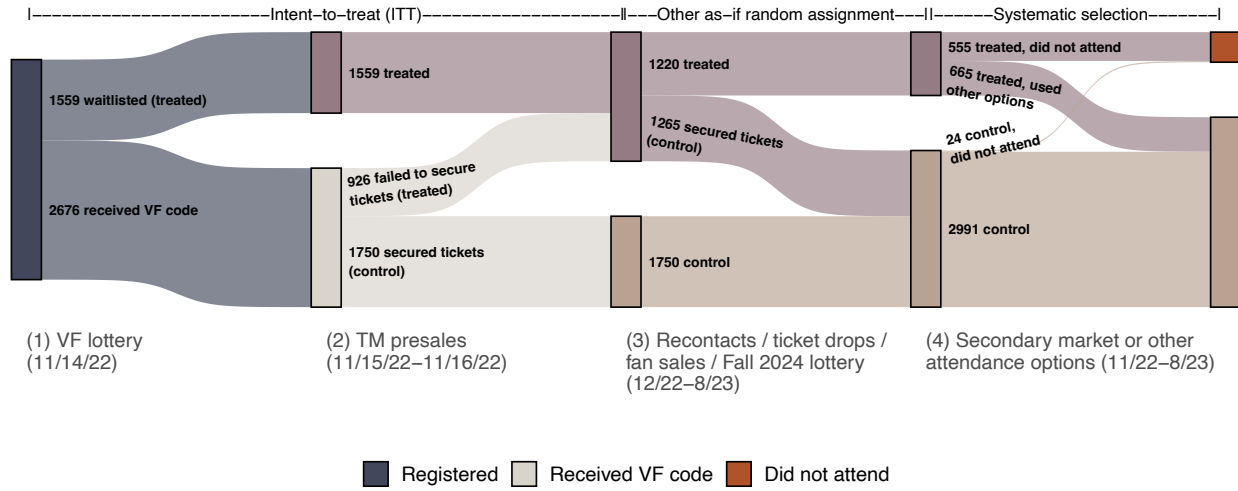


Note: Examples of how our elite Swiftie partners advertised the survey. Panels (a) and (b) are examples from X/Twitter and panel (c) is from SwiftStream.

I ended up getting tickets off of StubHub because after putting SO MUCH effort and time and energy into trying to get them at face value, I couldn't stomach not going to a show. I paid an outrageous amount, which I fully believe is also because of Ticketmaster...

This story reflects two relevant alternatives for defining treatment, which we illustrate in Figure 4. First, the experience of *failing to secure primary-market tickets* constituted a treated state. The application of this definition to only the November 2022 presales appears in the first two phases of the process shown in Figure 4. In the first phase, 1,559 Swifties in our sample were waitlisted in the Verified Fan lottery. Then, among the 2,676 who received a code, 1,750 secured primary-market tickets (control) and 926 failed to do so (treated). The result was 2,485 treated cases (1,559 + 926) and 1,750 control cases based on this definition in November 2022. This indicator (59% treated) is an intent-to-treat (ITT) variable because the primary-market ticketing process also extended beyond

Figure 4: Flowchart of Treatment Assignment Patterns



Note: The figure displays the flow of treatment assignment for the 4,235 survey respondents from November 2022 to August 2023. The first three phases were as-if random. The final phase reflected systematic choices to refuse or accept primary-market ticket failure and attend a show or not.

the November presales. It is our main treatment variable of interest in the analyses below.

However, we must also account for the fact that primary-market tickets were as-if randomly assigned by other mechanisms after November 2022. In the appendix (Section A6.1) we operationalize the same treatment definition (failing to secure primary-market tickets) by “flattening” time and coding an indicator based on Swifties’ November 2022 ticket-buying fates *and* the other as-if random opportunities that occurred in 2023. The third phase of the process depicted in Figure 4 illustrates this additional source of exogenous treatment variation. More Swifties secured primary-market tickets as a result of this phase, producing fewer treated cases than the ITT indicator $\left(\frac{1,220}{1,750+1,265} = 29\% \text{ treated}\right)$. Next, we coded a continuous treatment variable measuring the proportion of up to five unique pathways that fans attempted from November 2022 to August 2023 to secure primary-market tickets resulting in failure (mean = 0.65; standard deviation = 0.30). See Section A6.1 of the appendix for complete details on this indicator.

These measures only address variation in the as-if random nature of acquiring primary-market tickets. But if failure to witness The Eras Tour in-person substantively mattered most, then our first definition of treatment would require that everyone who secured primary-market tickets attended shows and everyone who failed to do so stayed home. Such perfect compliance with treatment

assignment did not occur. Some respondents who remained in the treated group across the first three phases of Figure 4 refused to accept their as-if random assignment to primary-market failure. This group of 665 Swifties—shown in the fourth phase of Figure 4—purchased tickets on the secondary market or utilized other systematic pathways to show attendance.¹⁵ The graph also illustrates that a small number (24) secured primary-market tickets, but did not attend a show.

Thus, our second treatment definition is an indicator for Swifties who, despite their many efforts to attend, were *completely shut out from The Eras Tour* at the time we fielded our survey. These individuals did not attend any show on the 2023 U.S. leg of the tour *and* did not secure tickets to any (including international) 2024 shows planned at the time. This variable—which includes 579 treated Swifties (14% of the sample)—represents a mix of (1) as-if random assignment to treatment or control and (2) systematic choices to refuse or accept primary-market ticket failure and attend a show or not. We account for this variation in treatment noncompliance in our estimation strategy (see Section 5.4 below).

5.2 Outcome Variables

Following past work, our preregistered outcome variables reflect multiple dimensions of issue engagement: attitudinal indicators and a direct behavioral measure with real-world implications (Krupnikov and Levine 2019). With respect to attitudes, we employ issue-specific importance questions to operationalize attitude extremity, which past work has used to study issue publics (see Ryan and Ehlinger 2023, 16–19). We designed our questions to capture both the specific issue—economic fairness in event ticketing—as well as its more general analog in society. Specifically, we asked about whether Ticketmaster’s lack of competition is a problem for ticket-buyers and whether monopolies in general are a problem for consumers. We also asked whether Ticketmaster should work harder to distribute tickets more equally and whether elected officials in the U.S. should do more to adopt policies that distribute wealth more equally. Responses indicated strength of

¹⁵These alternate pathways included familiar options such as receiving tickets as gifts or finding friends with tickets. But some Swifties in our sample reported taking extreme measures, including bribing security guards or taking jobs at the stadium venues to gain access to The Eras Tour.

agreement on five-point ordinal scales (see the preanalysis plan for exact question text and response options). H1 implies that treated fans more strongly agreed with the statements compared to the control group.

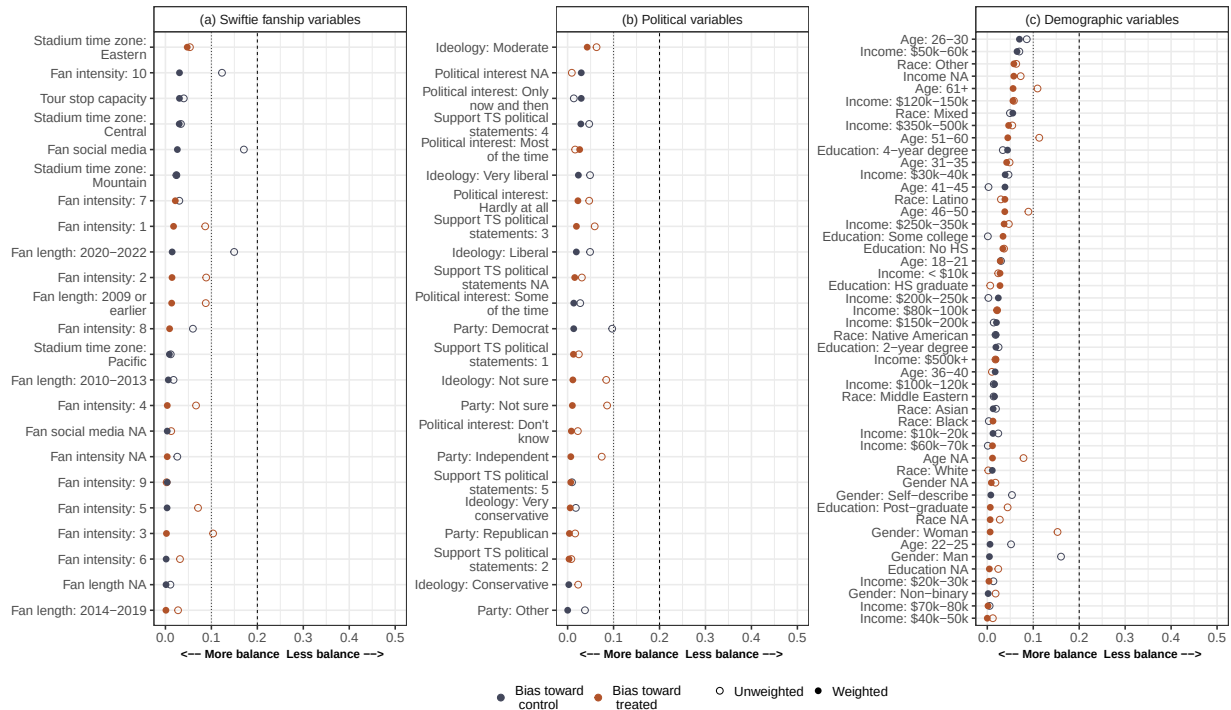
Additionally, we measured Swifties' self-reported behavior immediately after the presales and observed a highly relevant political behavior to issue public membership nine months later at the time of the survey. We asked whether respondents posted or commented online about their ticket purchasing experience, talked to other people about it, or contacted a government official or agency about their experience in November 2022. Our first behavioral outcome is a count of these activities. Additionally, the survey provided respondents with instructions and a link to file complaints with the FTC, a regulatory agency that handles consumer issues. We recorded whether respondents filed a complaint about their ticket-buying experience by asking them to provide a unique code from a completed report. As H2 suggests, we expect that treated Swifties engaged in these political actions toward ticket sale reform, even nine months after the sale, more than Swifties who secured tickets.

Finally, we preregistered two placebo outcomes. The first facilitates comparisons to attitudes on a different issue; we asked respondents whether the economic expansion of China has been good, bad, or had no effect on the U.S. economy. Given our theory, we expect that treatment did not impact responses to this question. Second, we counted respondents' engagement in a set of common political activities leading up to the November 8, 2022 elections. All of these activities occurred prior to administration of the treatment because November 9, 2022 was the last day to register for a Verified Fan code. Thus, the causal arrow would be reversed with this outcome and so we expect no treatment effect.

5.3 Covariate Adjustment

We do not claim that every Swiftie who attempted to register for Verified Fan status had an *equal* probability of treatment, as would usually be the case with researcher-controlled random assignment. However, we argue that the ticket purchasing process was marked by a sufficient amount of true randomness (via lotteries) and substantial unpredictability to support our claim of as-if random treatment assignment. Evaluating covariate balance and correcting imbalance are crucial steps in

Figure 5: Covariate Absolute Standardized Mean Differences Before and After CBPS Weighting Adjustment



Note: The graphs report absolute standardized mean differences for three sets of covariates before and after weighting with CBPS (Imai and Ratkovic 2014).

further strengthening identification (Dunning 2012). Figure 5 reports the absolute standardized mean differences of several covariates between the treated and control groups based on the ITT variable described above (the November 2022 presales results).¹⁶ We group these variables into indicators of Swiftie fanship (panel a), political measures (panel b), and demographics (panel c). The open circles represent the unadjusted data, indicating the covariate balance created purely by the natural experiment.

The results in Figure 5 validate the high degree of randomness in the ticketing process. All of the differences fall below a standardized mean difference of 0.20. However, they also show some anticipated systematic influences on treatment status. The most intense fans and those most engaged with the Swiftie social media community were somewhat more likely to be in the control group,

¹⁶Appendix Section A8 reports equivalence tests of the null hypothesis of meaningful differences (Hartman and Hidalgo 2018), additional balance metrics, and balance assessments of the other exogenous treatment variables.

because these Swifties made the most effort to acquire multiple Verified Fan codes. In other words, they were still subject to a lottery, but played that lottery more than others.

To address this issue, we estimate balancing weights using Imai and Ratkovic’s (2014) covariate balancing propensity score (CBPS) method. The objective is to improve balance between the treated and control groups on covariates by constructing a reweighted “pseudosample.” The covariates we use to generate these weights are fan intensity, fan length, fan social media engagement, partisanship, ideology, age, and gender.¹⁷ However, we assess balance on all of the respondent characteristics reported in Figure 5. The balance statistics for the weighted data appear in those graphs as filled circles. The weights are highly effective. All of the covariates’ absolute standardized mean differences are less than 0.10 post-weighting and many are essentially zero. Section A8 of the appendix confirms this finding with equivalence tests and other balance metrics. Thus, between the high degree of qualitative and quantitative evidence supporting treatment exogeneity and this additional adjustment, our design yields considerable causal leverage.

5.4 Estimation

We estimate treatment effects with weighted least squares regression models using the CBPS weights.¹⁸ In the analyses below we focus on two of the treatment variables described previously. The first is the ITT effect of failure to secure tickets in the November 2022 presales, represented by the first two phases of Figure 4. The other is the partially-endogenous indicator that redefines treatment as failure to (1) attend any show in 2023 and (2) secure tickets to a 2024 show (fourth phase shown in Figure 4). Because this “complete shutout” treatment represents a mix of as-if random assignment and selection into the secondary market or other systematic choices, we isolate its exogenous variation by specifying the November 2022 ITT variable as an instrument. This

¹⁷See the appendix for complete details on weight estimation (Section A7).

¹⁸To further mitigate confounding and improve precision, we include the covariates used in the CBPS weighting in the outcome models. Results are not dependent on this choice. We report robust standard errors to account for uncertainty from the estimation of weights and treatment effects. Bootstrapping the entire process produces substantively identical results.

strategy yields a complier average causal effect (CACE)—the effect among those whose show attendance aligned with their result in the Ticketmaster presales. In this context, the CACE is a substantively meaningful quantity. Compliers are those Swifties for whom securing primary-market tickets in November 2022 was determinative for seeing a show on the tour.

6 Results

Before testing our preregistered hypotheses, we discuss a manipulation check that provides empirical support that our treatment—failure in the November 2022 ticket presales—activated the *politics* of event ticketing for potential issue public members. We handcoded responses to a final, free-response question on the social media version of the survey for the presence (1) or absence (0) of any connection to the politics of event ticketing. Importantly, this question *did not* prime politics directly; it simply asked if there was “anything else [respondents would] like to share with the researchers.” We find that treated Swifties were significantly more likely to report a connection between their circumstances and event ticketing politics compared to the control group. This result bolsters the validity of the treatment as a means of testing our hypotheses, which we turn to next.¹⁹

We report ITT and CACE estimates below. Our analyses test the hypotheses with multiple outcome variables, so we report p-values corrected for the family-wise error rate (FWER). Estimates using the other treatment variables discussed in Section 5.1 appear in Section A6.1 of the appendix. These results are substantively almost identical to what we report below. In all cases, ordinal outcomes are standardized. Binary outcome effects are interpretable on the linear probability scale.

6.1 H1: Attitudes

Table 1 reports the estimated treatment effects and robust standard errors on differences in attitudes toward Ticketmaster as a monopoly, inequality in the distribution of tickets, and monopolies and inequality in general. Beginning with the Ticketmaster-specific outcomes, we find that those who failed to secure tickets agreed more strongly that Ticketmaster’s lack of competition is a problem for ticket buyers. The ITT estimate is approximately 11% of an outcome standard deviation

¹⁹Section A4 of the appendix contains the coding procedure, example text, and a full explanation of the estimation procedure and results.

in magnitude and its 95% confidence interval excludes zero. The CACE is considerably larger—just over half of an outcome standard deviation—and its 95% confidence interval is also bounded away from zero. On the question of whether Ticketmaster should work harder to distribute tickets more equally, the estimates indicate even stronger agreement among the treated group. The ITT is about 29% of an outcome standard deviation and the CACE is approaching 1.5 standard deviations.

Table 1: Estimated Treatment Effects on Attitude Differences

Outcome	Estimand	Estimate	SE	95% Lower	95% Upper	FWER p-value
Ticketmaster monopoly	ITT	0.105	0.031	0.044	0.165	0.004
	CACE	0.517	0.154	0.215	0.819	0.004
Ticketmaster inequality	ITT	0.292	0.033	0.227	0.356	0.000
	CACE	1.440	0.169	1.109	1.772	0.000
General monopolies	ITT	0.044	0.032	−0.017	0.106	0.214
	CACE	0.220	0.156	−0.087	0.526	0.214
General inequality	ITT	−0.036	0.029	−0.093	0.021	0.214
	CACE	−0.179	0.144	−0.460	0.103	0.214

Note: Cell entries report estimated intent-to-treat effects (ITT), complier average causal effects (CACE), and robust standard errors (SE) on differences in specific and general attitudes toward monopolies and inequality. All estimates are standardized and the p-values are corrected for the family-wise error rate (FWER). Estimation sample sizes for each outcome are 4,011 (Ticketmaster monopoly and Ticketmaster inequality), 3,991 (General monopolies), and 3,992 (General inequality).

The general attitude outcomes tell a somewhat different story. Regarding monopolies, the effects point in the anticipated direction; treated Swifties agreed more strongly that a lack of competition is a problem for consumers. However, these estimates are considerably smaller than the Ticketmaster-specific outcome effects and do not reach statistical significance. Moreover, the estimates on inequality attitudes point in the negative direction, suggesting that treated Swifties were *more* accepting of inequality in general relative to the control group. However, the confidence intervals for those effects also include zero.

6.2 H2: Behaviors

Next, we consider differences in behavior to assess whether failure to secure tickets motivated Swifties to engage more with the politics of the issue. The top panel of Table 2 reports the treatment effect on the count of up to three actions taken soon after the November 2022 presales (standardized). Because these underlying behaviors occurred immediately after the presales, we

interpret this quantity as an average treatment effect (ATE) rather than an ITT. It shows negligible differences between treated and untreated Swifties. The estimate is near zero and even the plausible values represented by its confidence intervals are somewhat small in magnitude as well.

Table 2: Estimated Treatment Effects on Behavioral Outcomes

Outcome	Estimand	Estimate	SE	95% Lower	95% Upper	FWER p-value
<i>November 2022</i>						
Total post-sale activities	ATE	−0.022	0.031	−0.083	0.039	0.482
<i>August-September 2023</i>						
Filed FTC report	ITT	0.020	0.009	0.003	0.037	0.043
	CACE	0.098	0.043	0.015	0.182	0.043

Note: Cell entries report the estimated average treatment effect (ATE), intent-to-treat effect (ITT), complier average causal effect (CACE), and robust standard errors (SE) on a count (0–3, standardized) of actions taken in November 2022 (top panel) and filing a report with the FTC in August-September 2023 (bottom panel). The p-values are corrected for the family-wise error rate (FWER). Estimation sample sizes for each outcome are 4,009 (post-sale actions) and 4,015 (FTC report).

The bottom panel of Table 2 reports ITT and CACE estimates on the probability of taking political action toward ticket reform nine months after the sale by filing a report with the FTC about Ticketmaster in August-September 2023. Completing this step was a fairly rare event—about 8% of our sample. However, it was significantly more likely among the treated group. The ITT estimate indicates that treated Swifties were about two percentage points more likely to file a report compared to the control group. And the CACE of about 10 percentage points shows that this behavior was much more likely among those Swifties who needed to secure tickets in the November presales in order to attend a show. Both estimates’ confidence intervals exclude zero. Moreover, they are particularly noteworthy given that respondents to our survey completed these filings with the FTC long after the original incident. While the treatment did not induce immediate differences in behavior (in November 2022), those who failed to secure tickets demonstrated a relatively longer-term change in political engagement compared to the control group.

6.3 Placebo Outcomes

Table 3 reports results for our two preregistered placebo outcomes. We present ITT and CACE effects as well as results from equivalence tests of the magnitudes of those estimates. The null

hypothesis is that substantively meaningful differences exist between the treated and control groups on those outcomes (Hartman and Hidalgo 2018).²⁰ Statistical significance rejects that null, yielding evidence in favor of the placebo test and the credibility of the design.

Table 3: Estimated Treatment Effects on Placebo Outcomes

Outcome	Estimand	Estimate	SE	95% Lower	95% Upper	ET p-value
China economic expansion	ITT	−0.014	0.033	−0.079	0.050	0.000
	CACE	−0.071	0.163	−0.390	0.248	0.038
2022 political activities	ITT	−0.044	0.030	−0.102	0.014	0.000
	CACE	−0.216	0.146	−0.502	0.069	0.162

Note: Cell entries report estimated intent-to-treat effects (ITT), complier average causal effects (CACE), and robust standard errors (SE) on differences in attitudes on the economic expansion of China and political activities prior to the November 2022 Ticketmaster sale. All estimates are standardized. The final column reports the p-value from an equivalence test of the null hypothesis of a substantively meaningful effect. Estimation sample sizes for each outcome are 3,843 (China economic expansion) and 4,002 (2022 political activities).

In contrast to the effects on attitudes toward Ticketmaster, the treatment exerted negligible effects on Swifties’ views about the economic expansion of China. The ITT estimate represents a difference of 1% of an outcome standard deviation and the confidence interval includes zero. The CACE is larger—about 7% of a standard deviation—but also not distinguishable from zero. Moreover, in both cases the equivalence test rejects the null of a meaningful difference at the 0.05 level. The ITT on the count of political activities before the ticket presales is similar: a small, nonsignificant estimate and an equivalence test p-value below 0.05.

The CACE on the political activities placebo outcome is somewhat different. The estimate is noticeably larger—about 22% of an outcome standard deviation. However, it is an inefficient estimate with a large confidence interval that includes zero. Its equivalence test p-value is also not significant, indicating that it is inconclusive as a placebo test. Large values—which would undermine the research design—are plausible, but so too are small values. Fortunately, because this variable is pretreatment by design, it can be included as a covariate in our adjustment strategy. Doing so yields no change to the results we present above (see Section A6.5 of the appendix). Thus,

²⁰We benchmark a substantively meaningful difference with Hartman and Hidalgo’s (2018, 1006) suggested value of 0.36σ , where σ is the pooled standard deviation of the outcome.

analyses of the placebo outcomes ultimately lend added credibility to our identification strategy.

6.4 Discussion

In summary, we find strong empirical support for our expectations within a narrow issue definition. Relative to the control group, treated Swifties (1) were more likely to reference the politics of the event ticket industry in free-response commentary (appendix Section A4), (2) viewed Ticketmaster’s monopolizing power over the ticket industry as more problematic, (3) more strongly agreed that the company should distribute tickets more equally in the future, and (4) were more likely to engage with government about the problem nine months later. They also did not diverge from the control group on our preregistered placebo outcomes. These findings provide clear support for H1 and H2 in the context of event ticketing.

However, we also find negligible treatment effects on attitudes toward monopolies and general inequality. On average among the Swifties in our data, the personal significance of the issue was localized to precisely what was relevant to them—ticketing for The Eras Tour—and not anything more. This finding reflects some limitations of issue publics as a solution to the democratic dilemma. By showing that issue public members do not generalize, our evidence suggests a path toward healthy democratic responsiveness that would require many issue publics, each representing specific issues. Somin (2016) argues that such myopia could lead to policy capture by organized interests. Another problem is the sheer number of potential issues; there may not be sufficient publics to cover the range of possible topics on which government plays a role. Others contend that even a partial set of very specific issue interests can consolidate useful information for policymakers, facilitating a solution (see Elliott 2020). Nonetheless, these shortcomings suggest at least some caution in interpreting issue publics as an antidote to the democratic dilemma.

Another point to consider as context for our findings relates to opinion heterogeneity within issue publics. In focusing on the identification of average effects, our analyses do not emphasize differences of opinion among Swifties in how to solve the problems associated with event ticketing. But in the appendix we show evidence for Elliott’s (2020) point that issue publics “span the spectrum of opinion” about their respective issues (388). We demonstrate descriptively that, while virtually all

Swifties in our sample held negative views toward Ticketmaster, there was variation in opinion on *how* to best address the issue. Some thought that Ticketmaster should reform itself, others thought grassroots collective action would be most successful, and many saw the need for government intervention of some kind (see Section A4 of the appendix for more details).

The appendix also contains supplemental analyses that further support our research design and results. We report similar treatment effects using our alternative treatment variables (Section A6.1). We also empirically verify that errors on Ticketmaster’s website were a source of as-if random treatment variation (Section A10) and demonstrate minimal heterogeneity in treatment effects by income or political interest (Sections A6.3–A6.4). Finally, we show that a representative sample of Americans displays more attitude variation on our general outcome measures, suggesting that our main analyses constitute difficult tests of our hypotheses (Section A11).

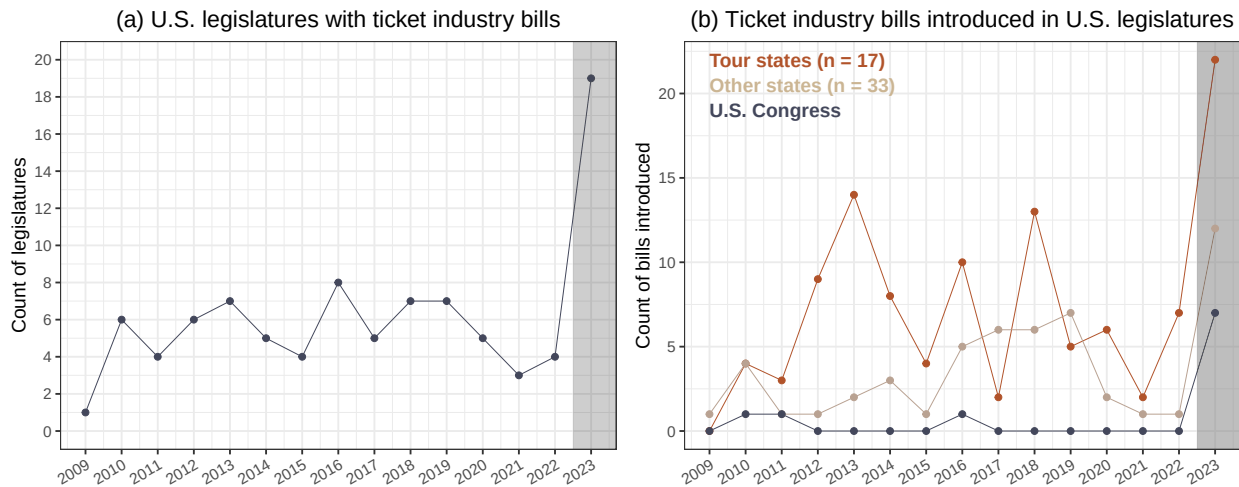
The long-term durability of the effects we report remains an open question. Ryan and Ehlinger (2023) argue issue public members have a long-standing interest in the political issue, even when it is not salient to the general public or covered by the mainstream news. Our results indicate noteworthy effects nine months after the pivotal circumstance, but our evidence does not provide insight into the dynamics of issue attitudes and behavior over an extended period. In Section A5 of the appendix we discuss the theoretical implications of this question. We also provide *anecdotal* evidence suggesting that treated Swifties’ interest in event ticketing politics was still apparent in 2024—more than one year after the November 2022 presales.

7 Issue Responsiveness

Our findings motivate one final and crucial question related to issue publics’ role in facilitating democratic performance: did elites in government respond after observing a “focusing event” (Kingdon 1995) on event ticketing politics? The Department of Justice filed suit against Ticketmaster in 2024 following a lengthy investigation that began shortly after the presales. Other government entities took up the issue at that time too, including the U.S. Congress, President Biden, state attorneys general, and state legislatures. We cannot empirically distinguish between responsiveness to the issue public and responsiveness to the extensive news coverage of Ticketmaster in late 2022.

But, as Figure 6 indicates, this attention from politicians on event ticketing reflected a notable increase compared to previous years. Both the number of total legislatures (state legislatures and Congress) with at least one ticket industry bill introduced in a year and the total number of bills increased dramatically in 2023 (see Section A12 of the appendix for details on these data).

Figure 6: Legislative Action on the Event Ticket Industry, 2009–2023



Note: Panel (a) presents a count of legislatures in the U.S. (state legislatures and Congress) that introduced at least one bill on the event ticket industry during 2009–2023. Panel (b) presents the number of bills introduced during that time in legislatures in states with and without a stop on The Eras Tour and in Congress.

This descriptive analysis falls short of identifying any causal effects and does not isolate responsiveness to the event ticket issue public specifically. However, it is useful for completing an empirical picture of democratic responsiveness. A pivotal circumstance highlighted a problem and activated latent issue preferences. Citizens communicated those preferences to government directly or indirectly over time. Politicians subsequently focused more of their policymaking efforts on that issue than they ever had in the decade prior. Of course, event ticketing may have been a relatively easy issue to address because the parties in government were not previously divided on it. Nonetheless, the 2023 legislation on event ticketing (which became law in several states in 2024) suggests a pattern consistent with responsiveness to this issue public’s preferences.

8 Conclusions

Converse’s (1964) seminal work has generated a wealth of understanding about Americans’ political attitudes, including the role of issue publics. However, this line of inquiry has generally

centered on the attitudes or behaviors of broad groups as identified by best-available survey questions and/or ex ante decisions by the researcher. The literature lacks clarity on the process by which individuals actually *join* issue publics. Our research highlights the value of stepping back to examine the theoretical underpinnings of issue public development. Our two-stage theory introduces the concept of a potential issue public—a group that forms the basis for personal connection to the issue. Individual self-interest, identity, and/or values are salient in the potential issue public, but the politics of the issue are latent. The second stage, then, involves a pivotal circumstance that activates the connection between a potential issue public member’s interests or identity and the issue’s politics. Those for whom activation occurs are most likely to join the issue public. The case of Swifties seeking tickets for The Eras Tour provides an opportunity to test this theory. The first stage is clearly met because Swifties are a long-standing, cohesive, and passionate fanbase who are likely to be repeatedly affected by the politics of the ticketing industry in the future. Then, a subset of the group confronted these politics directly, consequentially, and as-if randomly.

The empirical analyses support our theoretical framework: failing to secure primary-market tickets in November 2022 caused meaningful differences in treated Swifties’ political attitudes and behavior. These unlucky fans reported stronger agreement compared to those who experienced success that Ticketmaster’s lack of competition and uneven ticket distribution processes were problematic. They did not behave any differently from the control group initially, but nine months after the sale, they were substantially more likely to file a complaint with the FTC. They were also more likely to discuss the incident specifically in terms of the politics of the event ticket industry in open commentary. The “event ticket issue public” gained new members as a result of The Eras Tour and, as our final analysis shows, American politicians responded to this development.

The case of Swifties and The Eras Tour provides the first (to our knowledge) causal evidence on the roots of issue public membership, which yields insight into how issue publics may develop for other groups and other political issues. The concept of a potential issue public—represented here by Swifties—could broadly apply to numerous groups in society, including parents of newborns, social security recipients, electric vehicle owners, and many others. And these groups are susceptible

to pivotal circumstances as defined by our theory, such as formula shortages, shocks to available funding, or changes in the price of materials. Thus, while the specific details of our empirical analysis are unique, we contend that the theoretical process we propose holds broad generalizability that could provide a framework for further inquiry into the development of issue publics. For example, whether members of a specific issue public (e.g., event ticketing) could *eventually* form an issue public on the more general form of the issue (e.g., market competition) remains an open question. Our study assessed the specific and general versions of the issue contemporaneously, but a research design measuring attitudes and behavior over a longer period of time could provide valuable new insight and help further test and refine our theoretical framework.

Of course, it is also important to acknowledge the limitations of these findings. Our evidence comes from an issue that is not marked by mass or elite polarization and division. We also found minimal evidence that the Ticketmaster presales caused attitudinal differences among Swifties regarding monopolies or wealth inequality in the U.S. more generally. Thus, while the event ticket issue public likely grew due to this event, analogous groups concerned about these larger structural economic fairness issues in American society did not (at least within the timeframe of our study). Issue publics have long been identified as a potential solution to the democratic dilemma. And while the politics of the event ticketing industry represent a legitimate issue over which citizens can form preferences and politicians can act, it is a very specific aspect of the much larger landscape of American politics. The process of issue public membership that we observe may simply be too narrow to sufficiently enhance citizens' political engagement to overcome the democratic dilemma.

Our close examination of an issue public's development ultimately yields *cautious* optimism about issue publics playing a mitigating role in the democratic dilemma, reflecting the need for nuance in the study of democratic theory. Connecting the politics of an issue to a significant pre-existing personal interest or identity causes individuals, on average, to place more importance on and engage long-term with the issue, consistent with the image of responsible, informed citizens. However, these effects appear to be limited to the specific issue at hand rather than related, broader issues. Thus, issue publics may lay a foundation for healthy democratic accountability. But

improving citizens' capacity to influence elected officials' behavior in a major way likely requires that issue public members make connections between their personal concerns and larger structural forces in politics and society.

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The Development of an Issue Public: Evidence from The Eras Tour

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Appendix

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A1 Ethical Considerations

This section explains how the human subjects research conducted for this study adheres to the American Political Science Association’s (APSA) Principles and Guidance for Human Subjects Research. The authors’ Institutional Review Board (IRB) reviewed and approved the research on August 1, 2023 (Protocol Number 23-07-8003). The IRB determined the research to be exempt from human subjects research regulations found at 45 CFR 46.101.

The first screen of the online survey presented participants with an information consent sheet covering all elements of informed consent outlined in APSA’s Principles and Guidance for Human Subjects Research. After reading this information, we obtained participants’ informed and voluntary consent via an online survey question. Only participants who checked the box saying “I consent” proceeded with the survey.

The information sheet detailed compensation differently for the YouGov and social media samples. For participants recruited via YouGov, participants were compensated via YouGov. For participants recruited via social media, the information sheet explained that the researchers would conduct two drawings among an expected 4,200 participants who completed the survey for a \$500 Amazon gift card. The information sheet also made clear that to qualify for the drawings the participant would need to provide their email address at the conclusion of the survey to be recontacted if they were chosen. We randomly drew winners shortly after the survey closed on September 28, 2023 and delivered the gift cards in October 2023.

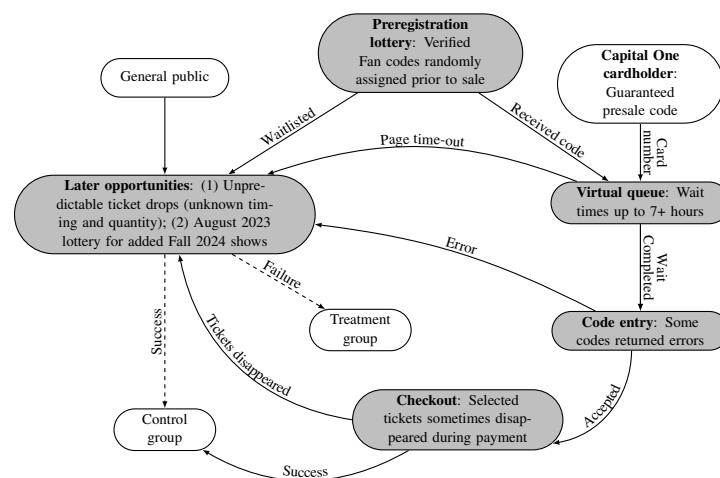
A2 Justifying the Natural Experiment

Dunning (2008) notes that natural experiments should be evaluated by empirical evidence and “by a priori knowledge and reasoning about the causal question and substantive domain under investigation” (289). Here we make a detailed substantive case for the Ticketmaster Verified Fan presales as a valid natural experiment under the potential outcomes model of causality (e.g., Morgan and Winship 2015). We describe the evidence in favor of as-if randomization of treatment and address several potential concerns related to the validity and generalizability of the treatment variable. In our view, this justification compares favorably to those of other studies on the continua of as-if random assignment plausibility and overall design credibility that Dunning (2008, 2012) discusses as means of evaluating natural experiments.

A2.1 As-if Randomization

We claim that the ticket purchasing process for The Eras Tour was marked by a sufficient amount of true randomness (via lotteries) and substantial unpredictability due to Ticketmaster’s server errors. Figure A1 depicts a stylized version of the process. In practice, some fans went through this process multiple times because they used more than one account and/or re-tried after failures. But because the November 18 public sale never occurred, all attempts at securing primary-market tickets included one or more of the as-if random points denoted in gray.

Figure A1: As-if Randomization of Primary-Market Ticket Purchasing Success or Failure in The Eras Tour Ticketmaster Verified Fan Presales



Note: Gray denotes events in which the immediate outcome was plausibly random and outside of the user’s control. Unpredictable ticket drops were only open to the general public and waitlisted fans through the Chicago shows (June 2-4, 2023; tour dates 29-31 of 53). Dashed lines denote paths that required all steps in the Ticketmaster process (virtual queue, code entry, checkout), which are omitted for simplicity.

Dunning (2012, Chapter 8) proposes a framework for evaluating the credibility of as-if randomness based on the *information*, *incentives*, and *capacities* available to units to select their treatment status. Here we summarize each of these criteria and evaluate them in the context of our study.

- *Information*: Do units know that they may be exposed to a treatment? Do other actors know which units are assigned to or end up in the treatment and control groups?
- *Incentives*: Do units have incentive to self-select into the treatment (or control)? Do other actors have incentive to allocate certain units to one group or the other?
- *Capacities*: Are units or other actors capable of acting on their incentives to self-select into or allocate certain units to treatment or control?

On the first criterion, Swifties elected to register and attempt to buy tickets. They knew that they would either purchase them from Ticketmaster successfully or not. However, we argue that they likely did not know this result would constitute possible exposure to a stimulus that might impact their political engagement and attitudes. They were simply trying to secure tickets to a show they wanted to attend. The only relevant “other actor” is Ticketmaster, which did hold some knowledge over treatment assignment and the groups in which fans ultimately ended up. However, that knowledge did not align with the incentives criterion. Ticketmaster’s only incentive was to sell tickets efficiently and maximize profit. Individual ticket-buyers’ subsequent political attitudes and behavior were irrelevant to Ticketmaster’s goals. Fans’ incentives were similar; all of them simply wanted tickets and politics was not a consideration.

Finally, Ticketmaster administered the sale, and thus had considerable capacity to affect the results. But its profit incentive would have driven Ticketmaster to only use that capacity to implement the preregistration lottery as described, then conduct the sale efficiently so as many fans as possible could purchase tickets. Perhaps, as many Swifties later maintained, the company could have done more in this regard. But Ticketmaster never held incentive to manipulate which fans did or did not receive access to tickets. In stark contrast to Ticketmaster, Swifties had essentially no capacity for self-selection. They believed (possibly incorrectly) that boosts would have moved them up in line, but obtaining boosted status occurred in 2020 (Lover Fest) and/or prior to October 21, 2022 (*Midnights* release), well before the tour announcement (November 1, 2022). Thus, boosts were completely disconnected from the ticket-buying process itself (see footnote 10 in the main text). Beyond planning and preparing to wait at their computer or mobile device for several hours on the day of the sale, fans were unable to alter their ticket-buying fates.¹

A2.2 Treatment Validity

Beyond the case for as-if random treatment assignment, it is important to consider several other aspects of the treatment variable’s role in a natural experiment. First, did the treatment really cause a meaningful difference between those who received it and those who did not (Mahoney 2010, 125)? We contend that it did in this case. The Eras Tour was not simply a concert tour, but rather an “ongoing mass cultural moment” distinguished by those who “won the Ticketmaster lottery and attended the tour” and those who did not (Horton 2023). It motivated engaged couples to change wedding dates, airlines to alter flight codes, and created a massive economic impact on host cities (Weatherby 2023). The nature of ticketed events—which by definition require individual-level access privileges—created a stark contrast between Swifties in the treatment and control groups as we define them. The fan community’s substantial online presence meant that those who failed to get tickets could still experience the shows on some level via video clips and social media discussion. But show reviews documented the clear difference between actually experiencing the event and not (Foggatt 2023). This point was further validated by fans who traveled to shows without tickets, hoping for a “miracle” outside the stadium (see Yahr 2023) or by online discussion such as a Reddit thread from June 7, 2023 titled “Non-concert goers, how’ve you been coping?”²

Another issue to consider is the overall relevance of the treatment (Dunning 2012, Chapter 10). How does the treatment switch on some phenomenon that social scientists truly care about? We argue that this empirical setting is extremely useful for gaining insight on a long-standing problem in the literature on issue publics. Ryan and Ehlinger (2023, 14) explain that “one reason research on issue publics has proceeded inconsistently is that public opinion researchers have never had a fully satisfying approach for identifying membership in issue publics.” They describe issue publics as groups that make political judgments based on “long-standing and emotionally charged psychological investment” in a specific political topic (14). However, this definition sets up a tautology: people gain membership because they care about a political issue for a long period of time, which immediately implies that membership informs their political attitudes (Ryan and Ehlinger 2023, 15). Our empirical setting breaks that circular reasoning by exogenously manipulating the *development* of an issue public.

¹Palus and Fung (2022) report that 90% of those who were unsuccessful in purchasing tickets completed their wait in the virtual queue, but experienced problems after that point. Thus, failure to secure tickets was *not* simply driven by fans running out of time or patience.

²Consider the emotion conveyed in one fan’s response: “it’s really hard for me to watch any video about the concert right now without getting emotional. . . . I’ve even found myself getting angry when I see literal children and preteens at the concerts. Like how could they possibly know the history and depth behind each of the albums/songs?”

Swifties in our treatment group were suddenly and as-if randomly forced to connect their deep-rooted fan loyalty to the politics of event ticketing.

Next, the potential outcomes framework makes an exclusion restriction assumption, in which assignment to the treatment group “only affects outcomes through its effects on treatment receipt” (Dunning 2012, 120). It would be violated if, for instance, those in the treatment group believed they were systematically singled out by Ticketmaster as not deserving of tickets and that perceived “outcast” status altered their political engagement and attitudes. Our assessment of fan reactions does not provide any support for this type of logic. Instead, while they expressed considerable frustration with Ticketmaster, Swifties generally appeared to view their ticket-buying experience as the result of bad luck (see Horton 2023). Similarly, we assume consistency: the treatment is defined specifically enough such that its realization maps onto the potential outcomes (Rehkopf et al. 2016).

A2.2.1 Spillover

Finally, we must assume no interference between units: the potential outcomes of each observation depend only on their own treatment assignment and not that of other observations (Dunning 2012, 119). A common manifestation of interference in the social sciences is spillover—untreated units receiving the treatment in some form through interaction with treated units. Given the online, tightly-connected nature of Swifties as a group and the extensive media coverage of the ticketing process, this assumption’s validity is a concern here. If fans who secured primary-market tickets (the control group) somehow vicariously experienced the impact of ticket-buying failure, our treatment effect estimates would be biased downward (Dunning 2012). The fact that many fans could not buy tickets was widely discussed, so our treatment was certainly not a secret to those in the control group. However, we contend that structural factors of the natural experiment mitigated this problem.

One key barrier to spillover effects in this case was the individualized nature of the treatment assignment mechanism. Each individual was required to possess their own ticket to see a given show, so the treatment was defined in specifically personal terms. Social media posts illustrate that many Swifties who attended the shows felt considerable empathy for those who were shut out by Ticketmaster. But there was a major difference between feeling disappointed for someone else and experiencing failure to secure tickets personally (see footnote 2 above). We contend that this individual-level treatment assignment process was not conducive to spillover effects. Indeed, it aligned strongly with the perspective that issue publics arise from situations of *personal significance* (Ryan and Ehlinger 2023, 4).

Next, we argue that simple awareness of the ticketing problems was not sufficient to treat an individual. As noted above, within the Swiftie community there was no substitute for actually attending a show (Foggatt 2023). Seeing The Eras Tour live and in person was vastly different from experiencing it through choppy, unreliable live-stream videos on social media. Many Swifties (treated and untreated) had knowledge of the circumstances surrounding Ticketmaster and the ticketing process for The Eras Tour. But that knowledge was not the crucial difference between Swifties that facilitated distinct attitudes and behaviors. The chance to experience the show itself was the key contrast relevant to testing our theory. This point aligns with the consistency assumption noted above.

Finally, to the extent that our study suffers from bias due to spillover, we expect that it would dilute our estimated effects. If fans who secured primary-market tickets still received a partial dosage of the treatment, the gap between them and our defined treatment group would narrow. Moreover, we would expect this reduction to be most concentrated in the Ticketmaster-specific outcome variables. Thus, this case likely represents a difficult empirical test of our hypotheses. The fact that we still find noteworthy treatment effects (in the Ticketmaster outcomes) suggests that our study does, in fact, identify the key contrast (as mentioned above) and/or that the treatment was powerful enough to overcome any spillovers.

A3 Data Collection Details

This section contains additional information on data collection, including recruitment, an assessment of respondent attentiveness, and descriptive statistics on our survey sample.

A3.1 Recruitment

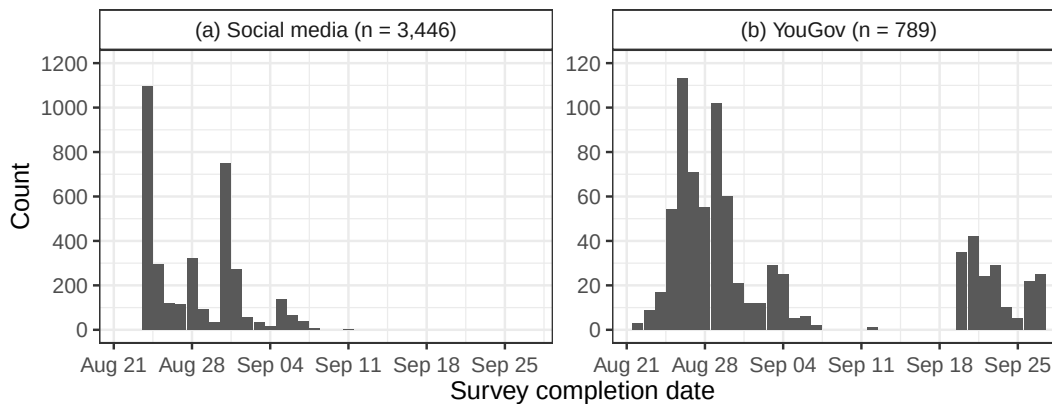
YouGov screened about 40,000 U.S. panelists in June-July 2023 to learn about their participation in the November 15-16, 2022 Ticketmaster presales. Then, YouGov recontacted those who were waitlisted (4%) or participated (5%) in the presales themselves to participate in our survey. To recruit Swifties online, we coordinated with several “elite” Swifties who represent large, significant nodes in the networks of the fan community. Those who posted our survey link on X/Twitter were @inmygreatwarera, @Kat_AF13, @erastourticketz, and @reckedmaserati (see footnote 12 in the main text). The first three rose to prominence by coordinating the collection and distribution of information about how Ticketmaster sales work, specifically alerting Swifties in real time to Ticketmaster’s ticket drops described in Figure A1. The final Twitter Swiftie rose to prominence by creating the popular “Swiftball” game, which is played by filling out a ballot predicting what will happen

during each show, like the outfits Swift will wear, the acoustic set songs she will sing, and more (Defusto 2023). During the U.S. leg of the tour, thousands of people participated in each game of Swiftball, with over 33,000 participants on the final night in Los Angeles.

We also coordinated with the Swiftie maintainer of <https://swiftstream.io/>, a popular avenue for watching livestreams of The Eras Tour, to share the link on the website surrounding the Mexico City tour stop (August 24–27). Livestreaming concerts is a process where individuals at the show use social media’s real time video sharing features to film and stream the show on their smartphones. Rather than each fan searching for the best livestream of The Eras Tour each night, <https://swiftstream.io/> and other Swifties did that coordination work for the fans, finding and sharing the best livestream in real time with thousands of viewers each night of the tour (Draughorne 2023). To compensate the time and effort of all of the Swifties who coordinated with us for survey distribution, we provided each with a \$100 Amazon gift card (@reckedmaserati declined).

Our survey was in the field from August 22 to September 28, 2023. Figure A2 graphs the distributions of responses over this time period by sample. A large share of responses were recorded in the first few days, during the Mexico City shows. Most responses were completed in the first two weeks, especially in the social media sample. YouGov increased their recruitment efforts in late September to fulfill our contracted number of at least 800 respondents.³

Figure A2: Distributions of Survey Completion Dates by Sample



Note: The graph presents the distributions of completed responses to the survey by sample during the August–September 2023 time period.

A3.2 Attentiveness and Data Quality

YouGov administered attention check questions and removed participants who exhibited a pattern of inattentiveness. As a second data quality control measure, YouGov also asked three Taylor Swift knowledge questions at the conclusion of the survey, excluding participants who incorrectly answered two or three (correct answer bolded): (1) Which of the following is NOT a Taylor Swift album? Lover, Fearless, Midnights, **Revival**, Speak Now, Folklore; (2) In which year was Taylor Swift born? 1986, **1989**, 1992, 1995, 1998; (3) Which of the following is NOT a Taylor Swift song? Back to December, You Belong With Me, Cruel Summer, Blank Space, Anti-Hero, **Plastic Hearts**.

We omitted attention check and knowledge questions from our survey posted in the online Swiftie communities. Instead, we first assess attentiveness and data quality using survey completion time. The median time to complete the survey was 9.90 minutes, with an interquartile range of 7.32 minutes to 15 minutes, suggesting that the Swiftie participants were attentive to the survey by taking their time answering the questions. Our second measure of attentiveness and data quality comes from participation in a final free-response text question asking if the participant would like to share anything else with the researchers.⁴ While optional, 43% of participants took the opportunity to write something in this text box. Of those participants, the median number of words written was 58 with an interquartile range of 30 to 107 words, suggesting that participants had a high level of engagement with the survey. Indeed, we found in our own read of these responses that participants took the survey seriously as an opportunity to share detailed accounts of the time, effort, and emotional toll it took to secure tickets to The Eras Tour. We expect this high-quality participation translates to the closed-ended survey questions, as well.

³ A total of 821 respondents completed the YouGov version of the survey. Our data cleaning process removed 32 of these respondents in producing the final sample for analyses.

⁴ See Section A4 for details on our coding of this text for political discussion.

A3.3 Sample Descriptive Statistics

Table A1 presents descriptive statistics across the survey sample by source, which demonstrates the importance of our multifaceted sampling strategy. Posting the survey directly in fanbase communities allowed us to recruit more long-standing and passionate fans. The majority of the social media sample reported being fans since 2009 or earlier—55.35% compared to only 26.36% of the YouGov sample.⁵ The social media sample respondents also hold their “Swiftie” identity more strongly, on average. On a ten-point scale, where ten indicates extremely significant, the mean significance of Swiftie identity in the social media sample is 7.63 versus 6.61 in the YouGov sample. Finally, recruiting in Swiftie online spaces resulted in younger participants (mean age of 29 versus 37) with less income (38.20% versus 26.72% making less than \$70K a year). Importantly, the YouGov sample allowed us to reach a more politically diverse sample of Swifties, including a higher proportion of Republican Swifties (7.40% of the social media sample versus 22.31% of the YouGov sample).

The tour stop capacity variable listed in Table A1 is a measure of local demand for tickets that individuals experienced during the November 2022 presales. The Eras Tour stopped exclusively at stadiums of teams in the National Football League (NFL) during the first U.S. leg. However, these stadiums vary in their capacity, from a minimum of 61,500 at Soldier Field in Chicago to a maximum of 82,500 at MetLife Stadium in East Rutherford, New Jersey.⁶ Additionally, the tour stopped in cities for two, three, or (in the case of Los Angeles) six nights. Thus, there was individual-level variation in demand depending on which shows Swifties elected to register for Verified Fan access. To measure individual local demand, we first computed the capacity of a tour stop as the stadium’s capacity multiplied by the number of nights in the stop. Then, at the individual level we computed the mean of this variable for all of the tour stops that each survey respondent selected when registering for the presales.

Table A1: Descriptive Statistics Across Samples for Fanship, Political, and Demographic Variables

	Social media sample	YouGov sample
Fanship variables		
Significance of Swiftie identity (mean on a 10-point scale, 10 = Extremely significant)	7.63 (2.32)	6.61 (2.64)
Engagement with Swiftie social network community (mean on a 4-point scale, 4 = A lot)		
TikTok	2.53 (1.13)	2.43 (1.24)
Twitter	2.66 (1.15)	2.59 (1.24)
Reddit	1.73 (0.98)	2.02 (1.13)
Tumblr	1.72 (0.99)	1.94 (1.13)
Instagram	2.72 (1.01)	2.96 (1.13)
Fan length		
2009 or earlier	55.35%	26.36%
2010-2013	21.44%	20.15%
2014-2019	14.88%	31.69%
2020-2022	8.34%	21.80%
Missing	0.12%	0.00%
Tour stop capacity (mean [stadium capacity × shows at tour stop] for shows registered for VF access)	199,722 (66,896)	195,431 (64,243)
Political variables		
Support Swift making political statements (mean on a 5-point scale, 5 = Strongly support)	4.54 (0.82)	4.08 (1.00)
Follow politics (mean on a 4-point scale, 4 = Most of the time)	1.95 (0.85)	1.70 (0.83)
Ideology (mean on a 5-point scale, 5 = Very conservative)	2.00 (0.90)	2.56 (1.07)
Partisanship		
Strong Democrat	45.13%	44.61%
Weak Democrat	18.20%	17.11%
Lean Democrat	14.73%	7.10%
Independent	6.83%	5.58%
Lean Republican	2.88%	2.28%
Weak Republican	4.72%	10.39%
Strong Republican	2.85%	11.91%
Not sure/missing	6.82%	1.01%
Demographic variables		
Age (mean years)	29.08 (8.08)	36.90 (10.98)
Race		
White	82.11%	79.47%
Black	1.60%	7.86%
Hispanic/Latino	12.38%	7.86%
Asian	7.97%	3.17%
Native American	1.30%	0.51%
Middle Eastern	1.24%	0.13%

⁵For context, Swift released her first album in 2006 and won her first Album of the Year Grammy for the country album *Fearless* in 2010.

⁶Capacity for concerts is different from that of football games, but we expect the two numbers to display strong positive association.

Two or more races	2.16%	0.76%
Other/self-describe	0.65%	0.25%
Missing	2.00%	0.00%
Gender		
Woman	83.44%	67.68%
Man	13.35%	32.32%
Non-binary	2.85%	0.00%
Self-describe	0.36%	0.00%
Missing	2.21%	0.00%
Education		
No high school degree	0.65%	0.89%
High school graduate	6.82%	9.63%
Some college, but no degree (yet)	22.74%	8.87%
2-year college degree	6.23%	9.13%
4-year college degree	41.74%	40.81%
Post-graduate degree	21.82%	30.67%
Missing	2.12%	0.00%
Income		
Less than 10K	1.29%	1.85%
10K - 20K	2.06%	2.25%
20K - 30K	3.78%	3.57%
30K - 40K	6.12%	4.37%
40K - 50K	7.80%	3.44%
50K - 60K	8.71%	6.08%
60K - 70K	8.43%	5.16%
70K - 80K	8.64%	11.90%
80K - 90K	11.02%	10.19%
100K - 120K	12.52%	12.70%
120K - 150K	8.57%	15.48%
150K - 200K	8.92%	10.45%
200K - 250K	5.84%	4.50%
250K - 350K	3.57%	4.37%
350K - 500K	1.40%	1.85%
500K or more	1.33%	1.85%
Missing	17.03%	4.18%
N	3446	789

Note: Cell entries report percentages except for significance of Swiftie identity, tour stop capacity, support Swift making political statements, follow politics (political interest), ideology, and age, for which we report means with standard deviations in parentheses.

A4 Political Text Handcoding and Analysis

Our theory posits that a pivotal circumstance—such as the November 2022 presales—activates the politics of the relevant issue for potential issue public members, increasing their likelihood of joining the issue public. Here we assess empirical support specifically for this political activation process as a manipulation check. Were unlucky Swifties more likely than those who succeeded in the presales to connect their personal ticket-buying fates to the politics of the event ticket industry?

A4.1 Handcoding Procedure

The final question of our survey asked participants in the social media sample the following optional, open-ended question.⁷ Importantly, this question *did not* prime politics directly; it was simply free space for respondents to provide additional comments.

Before you go, is there anything else you'd like to share with the researchers? For example, our questions might not have allowed you to fully share...

- How you got your tickets
- Your thoughts on Ticketmaster
- Your hopes for ticketing procedures for future Taylor Swift tours

We handcoded responses (with treatment status blinded) for the presence or absence of any connection to the politics of event ticketing. We each coded half of the responses. We also both coded a random set of 100 responses to assess intercoder reliability. This process resulted in agreement on 96 of 100 items, corresponding to a Cohen's kappa (κ) of 0.9029. Landis and Koch (1977) denote values above 0.81 as almost perfect agreement. Thus, we are confident in the reliability of our coding procedure.

Specifically, we coded respondents as "1" on the outcome if their text discussed any of the following:

⁷The question was omitted from the YouGov survey due to space constraints. We estimated the CBPS weights using only the social media sample for the following analyses.

- Laws, legislation, bills, politicians, elections;
- Ticketmaster should be held accountable;
- Ticketmaster should be regulated;
- Ticketmaster's practices should be illegal, Ticketmaster should not be allowed to do something;
- Ticketing in the U.S. should be like in other countries;
- Collective action/power of Swifties working together;
- Monopoly, merger with Live Nation, inequality;
- The system is unfair, e.g., Ticketmaster prioritizes bots/scalpers because it increases their own profits.

We coded "0" if the text only discussed:

- Ticketmaster should take it upon itself to change its policies e.g., stop prioritizing bots, reform Verified Fan system;
- Description/venting about individual stories;
- Individual scalpers/bots are greedy.

A4.2 Example Text

The following full comments are examples in which the respondents describe their experiences with the Ticketmaster sale, but do not connect the issues they experienced to politics. We coded these examples as "0".

- When Ticketmaster uses the lottery system, like they did in their most recent Taylor Swift sale, there were less fans that were able to achieve a Verified Fan code, and they made it so scalpers had the same chance of receiving a code as an actual fan who has followed Taylor Swift for many years. In previous ticket sales, Taylor has had a reward like system, where they took data based on how much you listen to her, and if you bought certain items which would prove that you are more of a fan than scalpers, and I think that they should consider converting back to that method. I spent months looking for tickets through Facebook and Twitter, and met with so many scammers that I lost hope. Me and my friend were determined to find tickets on a resale site so we watched it all the time but it was very difficult because the ones that would drop under \$1000 would be sold immediately because of the high demand I was lucky enough to grab the tickets at \$1100.
- I got my tickets simply by luck and watching hundreds of tik toks and tweets about people who have done it before. It took me from 9am to 3:30pm to get tickets because the sale was initially delayed by 5 hours due to issues on the east coast. I missed class, took time off of work, and was luckily able to get them but if I wasn't and I put in all that effort I would not have been happy. So many people with boosts didn't get a code or didn't get tickets and I felt like I didn't deserve the tickets. I wish the process wasn't so time consuming and buggy.
- I did successfully purchase tickets during a Ticketmaster unannounced face value drop the day of the concert. However, I spent probably 50 hours researching and practicing for this drop before it happened.
- I really hope that in the future it will be easier to purchase tickets that are reasonably priced for a Taylor Swift concert. I had some trouble getting tickets because when Ticketmaster gave me a second chance, it was at a really inconvenient time and the time period felt a little short.

The next set of comments reflect a connection between the sale and event ticketing politics through one or more of the criteria listed above. We coded them as "1". Political text is bolded below for emphasis, with brief explanations listed in brackets at the end of each quote.

- **Ticketmaster has a monopoly on the ticket industry. Since they own most of the venues, artists really have no choice but to work with them and LiveNation. This is anticompetitive and stifles innovation and competition.** Ticketmaster needs to be more transparent about who is getting tickets. If the problem was simply too many fans for the amount of shows, there is no issue. Taylor can't perform forever. However, bots obviously got tickets despite Ticketmaster's so called "Verified Fan." **Probably the only solution is to break them up.** [*References to monopolies and their consequences*]

- I went to the eras tour twice and both times I got them through other fans that I found on the internet for face value or slightly above face value. **I really appreciate the community that sprung up on twitter, facebook and reddit in response to the frustration we were all feeling with the secondary market.** It was extremely frustrating that we felt **we had to cut out ticketmaster and the secondary sites (stubhub etc) and take it into our own hands** which introduced more risk. It's literally so frustrating that we can't use the secondary market because of scalpers which is sort of the point of it, is fan to fan sale. [*References to collective action among Swifties*]
- I ended up getting tickets off of StubHub because after putting SO MUCH effort and time and energy into trying to get them at face value, I couldn't stomach not going to a show. I paid an outrageous amount, which I fully believe is also because of Ticketmaster. **There needs to be a system in which people who buy tickets, even just to resell, canNOT sell for an outrageously higher amount than what they paid. This kind of policy seems to be part of the European sales for this tour, and it is ridiculous to me that it cannot also be enforced here in the states.** Also, being such a massive, successful company, surely Ticketmaster has the capability to completely block out all the bots being used to buy out and resell tickets. One of the most frustrating experiences of my life. [*Call for policy change and regulation*]
- **Elizabeth Warren will fix this if we let her.** [*Specific mention of a politician, implicit call for policy change*]

A4.3 Manipulation Check Results

Of the 3,446 Swifties in our social media sample, 1,497 wrote a text response, with slightly more coming from the treatment group using our first treatment definition (44% versus 42%). The fact that only some respondents wrote text presents an empirical issue—post-treatment selection into observation of the outcome. We consider three approaches to handling this problem. First, as suggested by Coppock (2019), we define the outcome such that omission of text indicates absence of political discussion (i.e., coded 0). Next, we subset the data to only those who wrote text and re-estimate the CBPS weights to create balance in this subset.⁸ Finally, we estimate a two-stage sample selection model in which the total treatment effect propagates through (1) a model of the choice to write text and (2) an outcome model that conditions on writing text. Table A2 presents ITT and CACE estimates using these estimation strategies on the linear probability scale.

Table A2: Estimated Treatment Effects on Free-Response Discussion of Politics

Outcome	Estimand	Estimate	SE	95% Lower	95% Upper	FWER p-value
(1) No text coded as 0	ITT	0.059	0.012	0.035	0.082	0.000
	CACE	0.318	0.067	0.187	0.449	0.000
(2) Subset to text-writers	ITT	0.113	0.025	0.064	0.162	0.000
	CACE	0.712	0.168	0.382	1.042	0.000
(3) Selection model	ITT	0.069	0.014	0.043	0.098	0.000
	CACE	0.357	0.091	0.194	0.556	0.000

Note: Cell entries report estimated intent-to-treat effects (ITT), complier average causal effects (CACE), and robust standard errors (SE) on a binary indicator for discussion of politics in the free-response text. The p-values are corrected for the family-wise error rate (FWER). The estimates come from the social media sample only; estimation sample sizes are 3,226 total respondents and 1,438 text writers.

Across the social media sample, about 13% of respondents (29% of text-writers) discussed event ticketing politics—a noteworthy share given the lack of priming in the question. Table A2 demonstrates that treated Swifties were substantially more likely, on average, to convey this political connection compared to those who secured tickets. Across the three estimation strategies and both estimands, the treatment effects are positive with 95% confidence intervals that exclude zero. The ITT estimates indicate approximately 6–11 percentage point increases in the linear probability of mentioning politics, unprompted. The effects among compliers are considerably larger; even the most conservative estimation strategy (no text coded 0) indicates a 32 percentage point increase in the probability of discussing politics within that group. In short, this analysis supports the political activation process in our theory. On average, treated Swifties were significantly more likely to connect the politics of event ticketing to The Eras Tour presale compared to the control group, suggesting that our treatment activated the political relevance of event ticketing as we expected.

⁸This method requires the untestable assumption that those who wrote text would have written text even if their treatment assignment had been switched (Coppock 2019; Aronow et al. 2019).

A4.4 Topic Heterogeneity

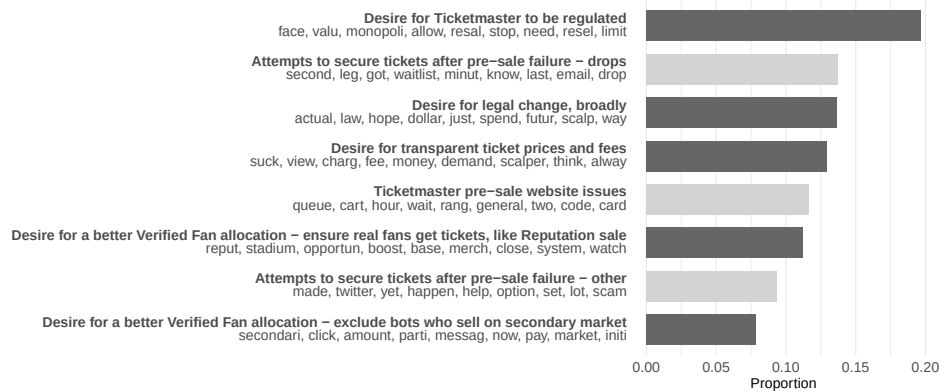
We also use the free-response text to explore the different ideas Swifties had in mind to solve event-ticketing problems. To do so, we estimate an unsupervised topic model with the responses in our sample that meet two criteria. We only use responses we identified in our hand coding exercise that connected the Ticketmaster issues to politics and were written by a treated Swiftie according to our first definition—failing to secure primary-market tickets in the November 2022 presales. This results in a sample of 308 written responses.

We use the `quanteda` R package to preprocess the text by tokenizing it at the word level, transforming all text to lower case, splitting hyphens, and removing punctuation, numbers, and symbols (Benoit et al. 2018). We also remove a set of 175 English stopwords and implement stemming. We remove one high-frequency term (ticket) and 1039 low-frequency terms that occur only once or twice in the corpus. Our resulting document term matrix is composed of the 308 documents and 820 unique terms.

We estimate a structural topic model with $K = 8$ topics (Roberts et al. 2014). Figure A3 visualizes the proportion of each topic in the corpus on the x-axis. The y-axis shows both our label for the topic and the topic’s topwords according to the frequency and exclusivity (FREX) metric. We determined our label for the topic by consulting both the top words and the most representative documents for each topic. Topics that discuss different ways event-ticketing problems could be addressed are shaded dark gray. Topics that describe the presales or subsequent attempts to get tickets are shaded light gray.

The most commonly discussed solution is Congress regulating Ticketmaster by breaking up their monopoly or limiting the resale of tickets. However, this is not the only idea Swifties expressed. They also hope for legal change, even if they cannot articulate exactly what that looks like. They also desire transparent ticket prices and fees, a reversion to past ticket-purchasing systems that reward real fans who purchase merchandise or watch music videos, and a better Verified Fan lottery.

Figure A3: Topics Discussed by Treated Swifties Who Connected their Event-Ticketing Issues to Politics



Note: Plot visualizes topic proportions in our corpus with FREX topwords and researcher-determined topic labels. Topics that discuss how event-ticketing problems can be addressed are shaded dark gray. Topics that describe the pre-sale or subsequent attempts to purchase tickets are shaded light gray.

Overall, these results demonstrate meaningful variation in treated Swifties’ ideas for the *process* of political change needed to improve event ticketing. This variation underscores a key difference between issue publics and groups that are organized in support of one particular side of an issue. Even those Swifties who were most likely to move from the potential issue public to the issue public expressed different views toward how to solve the problem. This heterogeneity is consistent with Elliott’s (2020) conceptualization of issue publics as composite structures, containing multiple subgroups with unique views. And while there is not strong disagreement within the particular issue public we study, such differences could be expected in other issue publics, such as morality policies (Mooney 2001). We show here that potential issue public members with a diverse range of opinions and perspectives were activated to join the issue public.

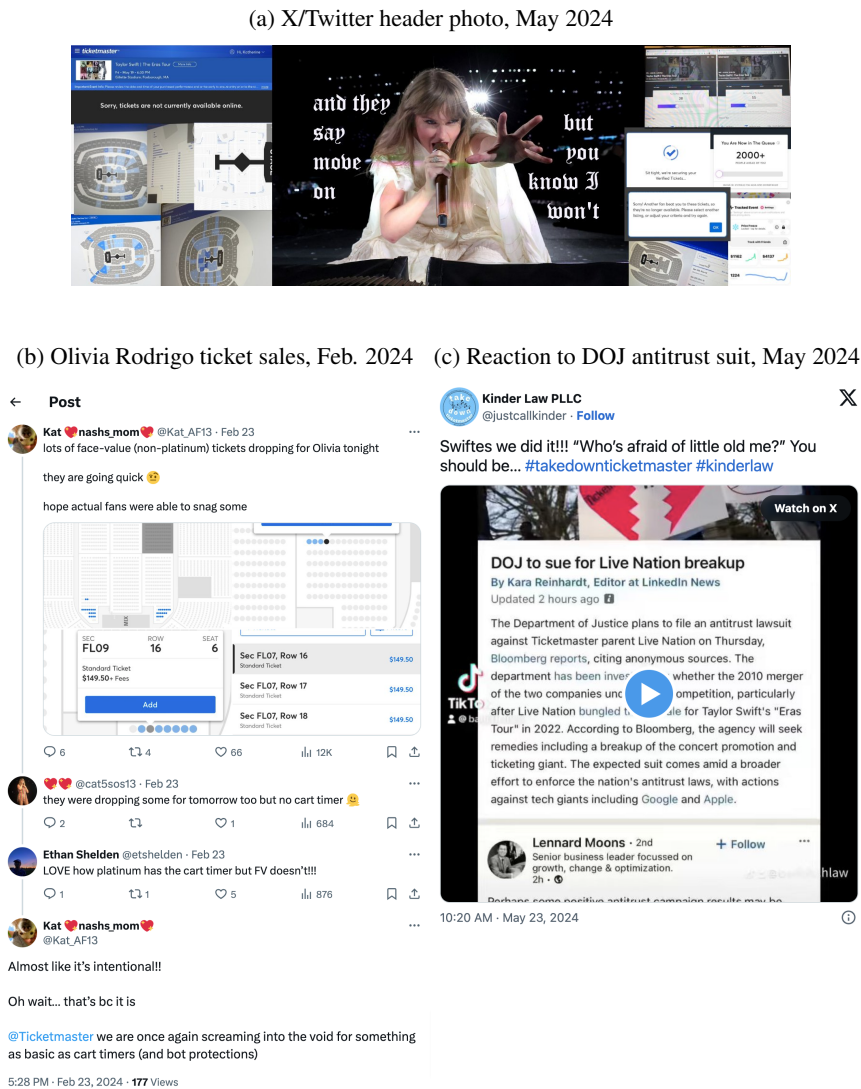
A5 Anecdotal Evidence of Long-Term Engagement

Did unlucky Swifties’ engagement with event ticketing politics persist over time? This question is important because issue public membership is defined, in part, by a long-standing interest in the issue (Ryan and Ehlinger 2023, 15). Recall our theory and evidence indicate that issue publics are smaller and more specific than their conceptualization in previous literature, which in turn suggests a revision to how long-standing the interest must be to constitute issue public membership. In line with our theory, we expect that the factors holding potential to personalize politics most for a person can shift throughout their life. Thus, pivotal circumstances can change the political issues one is passionate about and attuned to. Requiring that individuals follow the politics of an issue for a long time to claim issue public status would preclude the

emergence of issue publics on new issues.

Our research design was not ideally suited for understanding the dynamics of issue publics' attitudes and behavior. However, we can contextualize affected Swifties' long-standing interest with anecdotal evidence of their subsequent conversations and behavior. Prominent examples suggest attitude consistency, extension to other artists, and continued connection to politics well into 2024. Figure A4, panel (a) depicts a portion of a well-known Swiftie's header photo on X/Twitter as of May 2024, one and a half years after the pivotal circumstance. The image includes screenshots of issues and errors from the Ticketmaster presales with the accompanying text "and they say move on, but you know I won't"—referencing a lyric from Swift's song "mad woman." Panel (b) shows a February 2024 discussion led by this Swiftie about problems with Ticketmaster's sale for Olivia Rodrigo's Guts World Tour. And the tweet in panel (c)—posted by an attorney representing hundreds of Swifties in a class-action lawsuit against Ticketmaster—reacts to the Department of Justice's (DOJ) decision to sue Live Nation for antitrust violations in May 2024.

Figure A4: Examples of Swifties' Long-term Engagement with Event Ticketing Politics



A6 Additional Specifications and Analyses

This section reports additional specifications of our main treatment effect estimation strategies. We first present results using the other versions of our treatment variable. Then we show that our results are similar across recruitment strategies. Finally, we examine the possibility of heterogeneous treatment effects and report results in which the count of pretreatment political activities is used as a covariate instead of as a placebo outcome.

A6.1 Alternative Treatment Variables

We consider two additional versions of our treatment variable that account for the fact that Swifties were presented with other opportunities to buy primary-market tickets after the November 2022 sales (see Section 5.1 in the main text). The first is a binary treatment that "flattens" the November 2022 to August 2023 time period. It codes treatment status exactly

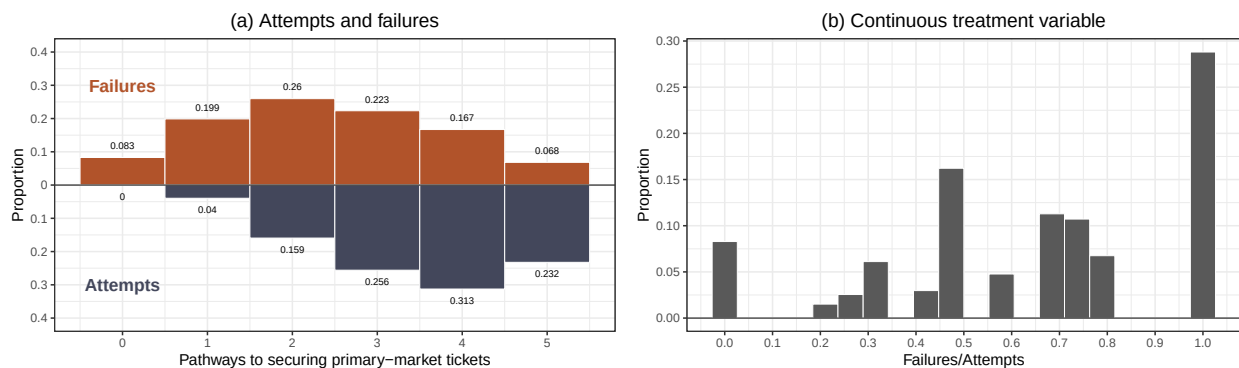
as the ITT variable described in the main text, but using information from all possible chances to secure primary-market tickets in the time before the tour, during the tour, and on the days of shows. Accordingly, compared to the ITT variable, this alternative measure places more Swifties in the control group (3,015 versus 1,750) and fewer in the treated group (1,220 versus 2,485). Most importantly, the additional opportunities were still dominated by as-if randomness and represent the full process that fans went through to obtain tickets. Thus, we contend that this “November-August” treatment variable identifies the average treatment effects (ATE) on the outcomes.

Our second alternative is a continuous treatment variable that measures the proportion of up to five unique pathways to securing primary-market tickets that resulted in failure. Over the course of the November 2022–August 2023 time period, fans tried some or all of the following strategies to secure primary-market tickets:

- November 2022 Verified Fan lottery;
- November 2022 presales;
- Ticketmaster recontacts or fan sales;
- Unannounced ticket drops;
- August 2023 Verified Fan lottery.

Our continuous treatment is comprised of a denominator representing Swifties’ efforts and a numerator corresponding to their lack of success. The former ranges 1–5 and the latter ranges 0–5. Figure A5, panel (a) presents histograms of these two components. In scaling failures by attempts, this strategy accounts for individual-level variation in effort to select out of treatment. Some fans tried many times and some were even successful more than once, while others tried only a few times.⁹ The final proportion—graphed in panel (b) of Figure A5—ranges from 0 to 1 with a mean of 0.65, a median of 0.67, a standard deviation of 0.30, and an interquartile range of 0.50. Larger values indicate a higher proportion of Swifties’ efforts to secure primary-market tickets failed. We report a marginal effect (ME) corresponding to a two-standard deviation shift in this measure.

Figure A5: Distributions of Attempts and Failures to Secure Primary-Market Tickets



Note: Panel (a) presents mirrored histograms of the components of the continuous treatment variable. The variable’s denominator is a count of attempts to secure primary-market tickets from the list of five unique pathways (downward-facing histogram). The numerator is the count of an individual’s attempts that resulted in failure (upward-facing histogram). Panel (b) presents a histogram of the continuous treatment variable, which is computed as failures/attempts.

Table A3 replicates Table 1 from the main text with these two alternative treatments. The ATE estimates come from the binary November-August treatment and the ME estimates come from a two-standard deviation shift in the continuous treatment variable. We find results that are substantively similar to what we report in the main text. The Ticketmaster-specific outcomes show substantively noteworthy positive effects that are distinguishable from zero and similar in magnitude to the ITT estimates from Table 1. Additionally, as in Table 1 we find weakly positive effects on the general monopolies outcome and effects near zero for the general inequality outcome.

⁹The correlation between attempts and failures is 0.69. That is, the more Swifties tried to follow these pathways, the more failures they accumulated. Furthermore, the correlation between attempts and complete failure (i.e., attempts equal to failures) is 0.04, indicating that trying more pathways was not strongly related to one instance of success.

Table A3: Estimated Treatment Effects on Attitude Differences with Alternative Treatments

Outcome	Estimand	Estimate	SE	95%	95%	FWER p-value
				Lower	Upper	
Ticketmaster monopoly	ATE	0.113	0.034	0.047	0.180	0.005
	ME	0.099	0.032	0.036	0.162	0.011
Ticketmaster inequality	ATE	0.375	0.033	0.311	0.439	0.000
	ME	0.306	0.033	0.241	0.371	0.000
General monopolies	ATE	0.016	0.036	-0.054	0.085	0.663
	ME	0.037	0.032	-0.026	0.100	0.663
General inequality	ATE	0.015	0.031	-0.046	0.076	0.663
	ME	-0.040	0.031	-0.101	0.020	0.663

Note: Cell entries report estimated average treatment effects (ATE), marginal effects (ME) of a two-standard deviation shift in the continuous treatment variable, and robust standard errors (SE) on differences in specific and general attitudes toward monopolies and inequality. All estimates are standardized and the p-values are corrected for the family-wise error rate (FWER). Estimation sample sizes for each outcome are 4,011 (Ticketmaster monopoly and Ticketmaster inequality), 3,991 (General monopolies), and 3,992 (General inequality).

The only behavioral outcome that is relevant to these alternative treatments is filing a report with the FTC. The actions taken in November 2022 discussed in the main text would have occurred before the other opportunities to secure primary-market tickets that the alternative treatments measure. Table A4 shows positive effects on the probability of filing a report, although the magnitudes are decreased slightly compared to the main text results (Table 2). The estimate with the November-August treatment (ATE) is positive, but its 95% confidence interval includes zero. The continuous treatment marginal effect (ME) is in line with the ITT estimate from the main text and distinguishable from zero, although its FWER p-value is slightly above 0.05.

Table A4: Estimated Treatment Effects on FTC Reporting with Alternative Treatments

Outcome	Estimand	Estimate	SE	95%	95%	FWER p-value
				Lower	Upper	
Filed FTC report	ATE	0.007	0.010	-0.012	0.027	0.479
	ME	0.019	0.009	0.001	0.036	0.068

Note: Cell entries report the estimated average treatment effect (ATE), marginal effect (ME) of a two-standard deviation shift in the continuous treatment variable, and robust standard errors (SE) on filing a report with the FTC in August-September 2023. The p-values are corrected for the family-wise error rate (FWER). The estimation sample size is 4,015.

Table A5 reports the estimates on the preregistered placebo outcomes. Here we find consistent evidence of null effects across both treatment variables and both outcomes. The estimates are small in magnitude (less than 5% of an outcome standard deviation), do not reach statistical significance, and pass equivalence tests. Thus, we reject the null hypothesis of a meaningful effect with each of our alternative treatments.

Table A5: Estimated Treatment Effects on Placebo Outcomes with Alternative Treatments

Outcome	Estimand	Estimate	SE	95%	95%	ET p-value
				Lower	Upper	
China economic expansion	ATE	-0.044	0.037	-0.117	0.029	0.000
	ME	-0.046	0.033	-0.111	0.018	0.000
2022 political activities	ATE	-0.036	0.034	-0.102	0.031	0.000
	ME	0.005	0.031	-0.056	0.066	0.000

Note: Cell entries report estimated average treatment effects (ATE), marginal effects (ME) of a two-standard deviation shift in the continuous treatment variable, and robust standard errors (SE) on differences in attitudes on the economic expansion of China and political activities prior to the November 2022 Ticketmaster sale. All estimates are standardized. The final column reports the p-value from an equivalence test of the null hypothesis of a meaningfully large effect. Estimation sample sizes for each outcome are 3,843 (China economic expansion) and 4,002 (2022 political activities).

Finally, Table A6 reports the estimates on discussion of event ticketing politics in the free-response text (the manipulation check in Table A2). Results remain substantively the same; positive estimates indicate that treated Swifties were consistently more likely to discuss the politics of event ticketing in their responses. Accounting for the additional opportunities to secure primary-market tickets in different ways does not alter our substantive conclusions.

Table A6: Estimated Treatment Effects on Free-Response Discussion of Politics with Alternative Treatments

Outcome	Estimand	Estimate	SE	95% Lower	95% Upper	FWER p-value
(1) No text coded as 0	ATE	0.039	0.014	0.011	0.067	0.006
	ME	0.044	0.012	0.021	0.068	0.001
(2) Subset to text-writers	ATE	0.084	0.029	0.027	0.142	0.006
	ME	0.082	0.025	0.033	0.131	0.003
(3) Selection model	ATE	0.048	0.016	0.017	0.081	0.000
	ME	0.088	0.024	0.042	0.136	0.000

Note: Cell entries report estimated average treatment effects (ATE), marginal effects (ME) of a two-standard deviation shift in the continuous treatment variable, and robust standard errors (SE) on a binary indicator for discussion of politics in the free-response text. The p-values are corrected for the family-wise error rate (FWER). The estimates come from the social media sample only; estimation sample sizes are 3,226 total respondents and 1,438 text writers.

A6.2 Sensitivity to Social Media Recruitment Messaging

Recall from the main text that we shared our survey link online via prominent members of the Swiftie fan community on social media. We sought to give these elite Swifties as much flexibility as possible to distribute the link in their own voices to their many followers. Beyond basic details about eligibility and compensation, we did not impose any restrictions on their recruitment messaging. We viewed this choice as important for maintaining trust with these individuals and the fanbase in general.

However, it is possible that ceding control over recruitment content could have facilitated a source of bias. Figure 3 shows that some of the messaging the elite Swifties selected included references to “holding Ticketmaster accountable.” This phrase may have primed some Swifties toward greater political engagement compared to how they would have behaved without such a reference. To illustrate the potential threat to our inferences, assume that the population is comprised of two types of Swifties: (1) those who become angrier and/or more politically motivated by bad luck with ticketing and (2) those who do not. Additionally, assume that messaging about Ticketmaster’s accountability motivates the type 1 group more strongly than the type 2 group. We do not have measures of these types, so we must assume that they are equally distributed across the treatment and control conditions in our data. But if after controlling for our covariates, type 1 Swifties are relatively more concentrated in the treated group and type 2 Swifties appear relatively more often in control, this priming effect could erroneously inflate our estimated treatment effects.

As a check, we conducted our analyses separately within each sample. The YouGov respondents were notified about the survey via conventional messaging from YouGov. They were told that they were eligible to participate and given instructions for completing the survey just like with other surveys they receive as panel members. They were *not* encouraged to participate with calls from other Swifties to hold Ticketmaster accountable.¹⁰ Thus, analyzing the YouGov data separately from those recruited over social media provides a useful look at our results in a sample that did not receive the potential priming described above. Table A7 reports separate estimates for three outcomes—the Ticketmaster-specific attitudes and filing a report with the FTC—in the two samples.¹¹

The attitudinal results in Table A7 align with those presented in the main text. Treated Swifties in both samples were more strongly in agreement that Ticketmaster’s monopoly and inequality in ticket distribution were problems compared to the control group. The magnitudes of the estimates are slightly stronger among YouGov respondents for the monopoly outcome and notably stronger among social media respondents for the inequality outcome. And despite the smaller sample sizes (especially for the YouGov sample), the 95% confidence intervals for the effects on attitudes all exclude zero, with

¹⁰There were also other differences in the YouGov respondents’ experience. For instance, they were compensated through their preexisting agreements as YouGov panelists rather than our gift card drawings (see Section A1).

¹¹We re-estimated the weights within each sample prior to estimating treatment effects. Generating good covariate balance and maintaining statistical power is more difficult in the smaller YouGov sample ($n = 789$). In that case we specified the same set of covariates to generate weights, but used a nonparametric version of CBPS (Fong et al. 2018), which performs better with respect to balance and effective sample size. We also omitted covariates in the effect estimation stage for that sample because including them inflates standard errors (but treatment effect magnitudes remain similar).

Table A7: Estimated Treatment Effects by Sample

Outcome	Estimand	Sample	Estimate	SE	95% Lower	95% Upper	FWER p-value
Ticketmaster monopoly	ITT	YouGov	0.153	0.076	0.004	0.302	0.044
		Social media	0.095	0.035	0.026	0.164	0.010
	CACE	YouGov	0.562	0.276	0.022	1.103	0.044
		Social media	0.493	0.191	0.119	0.867	0.010
Ticketmaster inequality	ITT	YouGov	0.153	0.072	0.011	0.294	0.044
		Social media	0.320	0.037	0.248	0.392	0.000
	CACE	YouGov	0.561	0.270	0.032	1.090	0.044
		Social media	1.681	0.207	1.275	2.087	0.000
Filed FTC report	ITT	YouGov	0.009	0.016	−0.023	0.042	0.570
		Social media	0.025	0.010	0.006	0.045	0.011
	CACE	YouGov	0.034	0.060	−0.084	0.152	0.570
		Social media	0.139	0.054	0.034	0.244	0.011

Note: Cell entries report estimated intent-to-treat effects (ITT), complier average causal effects (CACE), and robust standard errors (SE) for select outcome variables in the YouGov and social media samples separately. The p-values are corrected for the family-wise error rate (FWER). The YouGov sample includes 789 respondents for all outcomes. Estimation sample sizes for each outcome in the social media sample are 3,222 (Ticketmaster monopoly and Ticketmaster inequality) and 3,226 (Filed FTC report).

FWER p-values below 0.05.

The estimated effects on filing a report with the FTC are positive (in line with H2), but smaller in magnitude among those in the YouGov sample. However, FTC report filing was less common in that sample (5%) compared to the social media sample (9%). Thus, we contend that estimates of one (ITT) or three (CACE) percentage point increases in the likelihood of filing a report are actually substantively meaningful in that context. However, it is also important to note that positive *and* negative estimates are plausible in the YouGov data. The reduced power of a smaller sample means we cannot reject the null of no effect at the 95% level. As in the full sample of data, the social media sample shows large estimates on FTC filing with confidence intervals that exclude zero and FWER p-values below 0.05.

We focus on these three outcomes because they exhibited non-zero treatment effect estimates in the main text, but our results by sample with the other outcome variables also reflect the same general patterns as the full sample. Overall, these results justify confidence in our full sample estimates and support our substantive conclusions. Any impact of the possible priming issue discussed above was likely minimal because the treatment effects were similar in a sample that was recruited to the survey through a different means.

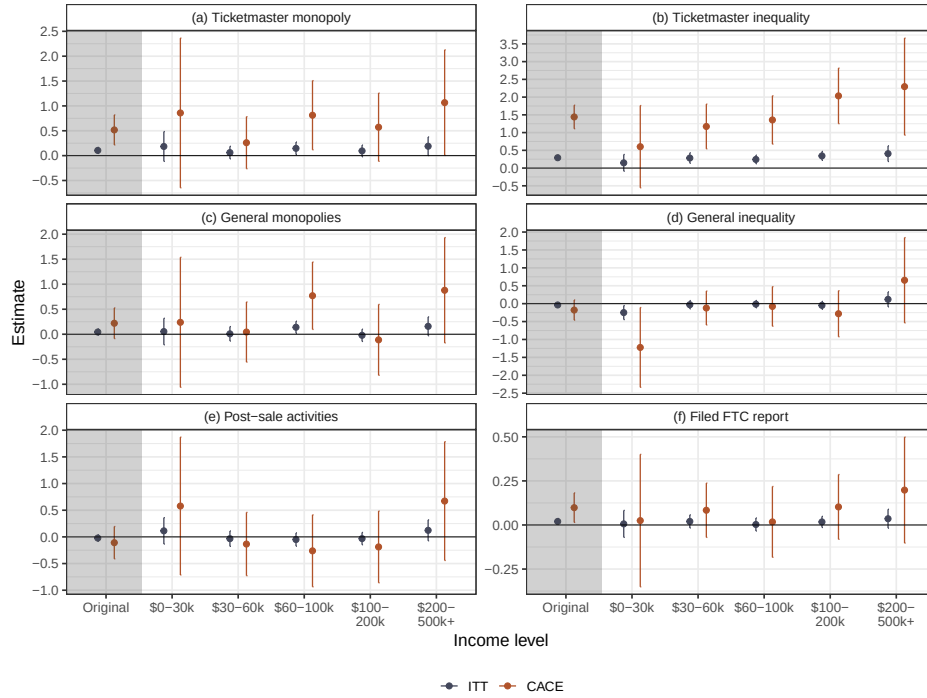
A6.3 Heterogeneous Treatment Effects by Income Level

Given the high cost of tickets to The Eras Tour, it is important to consider the role of income in shaping Swifties' decisions and attitudes. Figure A6 reports estimated treatment effects (ITT and CACE) on the outcomes reported in Tables 1 and 2 (main text). The first sets of estimates (gray shading) are the original estimates from Tables 1 and 2, which average over income levels. The other estimates come from models in which treatment is interacted with a five-category income variable.

The general pattern in Figure A6 is relatively constant effects across income categories. Within each estimand, virtually all of the estimates are not substantively or statistically distinguishable from each other. The one slight exception is in panel (b), which shows the effects on the Ticketmaster inequality outcome. The CACE estimates show an upward trend, indicating that the treatment effect on attitudes toward inequality in ticket distribution as a problem increases in income. This finding is somewhat counterintuitive. Although we did not preregister any hypotheses, a likely expectation would be that *lower* income respondents would react more strongly in a negative direction to inequality because they likely had less access to tickets on the secondary market.¹²

¹²Our data show a substantively and statistically significant positive association between income and buying from the secondary market, controlling for treatment and a comprehensive set of covariates (see the replication materials).

Figure A6: Estimated Treatment Effects by Income Level



Note: The graphs present ITT and CACE estimates and 95% confidence intervals by income level for the outcomes reported in Tables 1 and 2. The estimates in shaded boxes on the left side represent the original estimates (without the income interaction).

A6.4 Heterogeneous Treatment Effects by Political Interest

Another possible source of variation in the treatment effects is pretreatment political interest. Perhaps unlucky Swifties who were attentive to politics prior to The Eras Tour channeled their personal experience with the ticket presales into political attitudes and behavior more than those who were not interested in politics. Figure A7 reports estimated treatment effects (ITT and CACE) on the outcomes reported in Tables 1 and 2 (main text). As with Figure A6, the first sets of estimates (gray shading) are the original estimates from Tables 1 and 2, which average over political interest levels. The other estimates come from models in which treatment is interacted with four categories of attention to government and public affairs.

As with income, we find relatively constant effects across political interest categories. Figure A7 shows that most of the estimates within an estimand are statistically indistinguishable from each other. We do not see a clear increasing pattern from left to right within each graph, which would support the expectation that the treatment effects were weaker among the least interested and stronger among Swifties who pay more attention to politics. If anything, the largest treatment effects emerge among respondents in the “hardly at all” category for several outcomes: Ticketmaster monopoly (panel a), general monopolies (panel b), general inequality (panel d), and post-sale activities (panel e). But given that we lack any prior theoretical expectation pointing to this finding, we do not interpret it much beyond a chance result due to statistical noise.

A6.5 Controlling for Pretreatment Political Activities

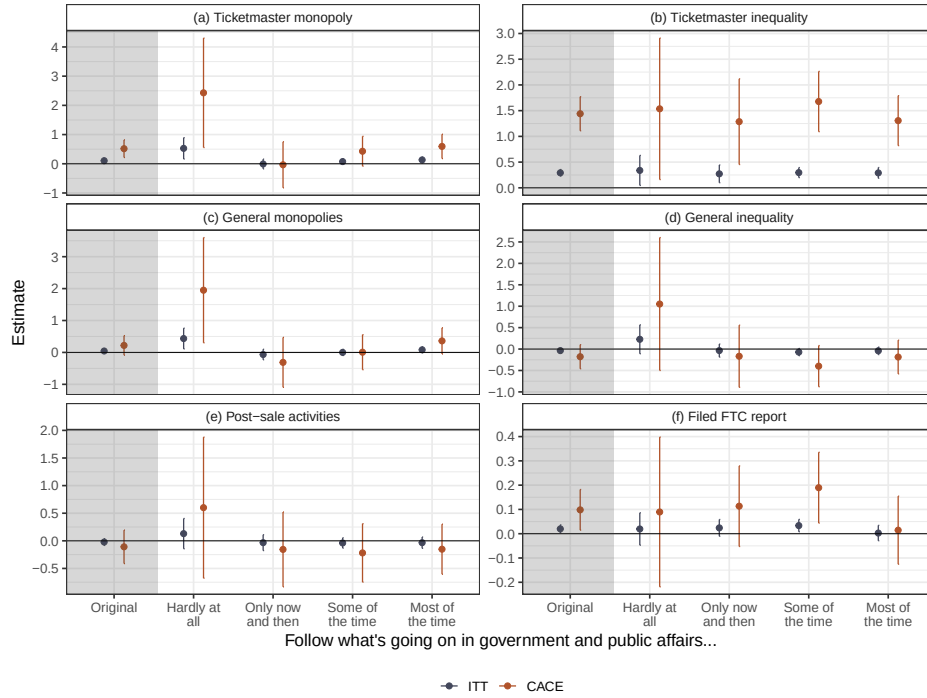
In our discussion of Table 3 we note that the CACE estimate on the political activities placebo outcome is inconclusive because large negative, large positive, and negligible values are all plausible given the confidence interval. Because this variable is pretreatment by design, it can be included as a covariate in our adjustment strategy. Figure A8 reports the ITT and CACE estimates from the original specification and with the variable included in the weighting and estimation specifications. The graphs show that there are essentially no differences in the estimates after balancing on pretreatment political activities.

A7 Weight Estimation and Assessment

Here we provide further details on our weights used to improve covariate balance. This discussion describes weight estimation with our full sample of data.¹³ We include the following variables in the specification for weight estimation: Fan length (factor), Swiftie social media engagement, Partisanship (factor), Ideology (factor), Age, and Gender (factor). We employ a fully-flexible parameterization for many of the variables and include them in the specification with indicators variables for each factor level. The two exceptions are Swiftie social media engagement and age, which are entered as linear terms. Estimating the weights with these variables in the specifications induces very strong covariate balance on them as

¹³See the replication materials for details on weight estimation in the data subsets used to analyze the free-response text (Table A2).

Figure A7: Estimated Treatment Effects by Political Interest



Note: The graphs present ITT and CACE estimates and 95% confidence intervals by political interest for the outcomes reported in Tables 1 and 2. The estimates in shaded boxes on the left side represent the original estimates (without the interest interaction).

well as additional covariates correlated with these variables. See Section A8 below for more details on covariate balance, with and without the weights.

We generate our balancing weights using Imai and Ratkovic’s (2014) covariate balancing propensity score (CBPS) method, which estimates a propensity score for treatment assignment such that covariate balance is optimized. We selected CBPS over a range of other options based on balance improvement and effective sample size. For instance, we considered several matching procedures (Ho et al. 2011). These methods improved balance, but at the cost of approximately 25% of our cases. Several weighting estimators—including entropy balancing, optimization weighting, and energy balancing (Greifer 2024b)—also balance the data well, but with much less loss of information. CBPS emerges as the best solution, yielding weights with reasonable distributions and effective sample sizes no worse than about 94% of the original sample (4,235). Table A8 summarizes the weights for our three treatment variables.

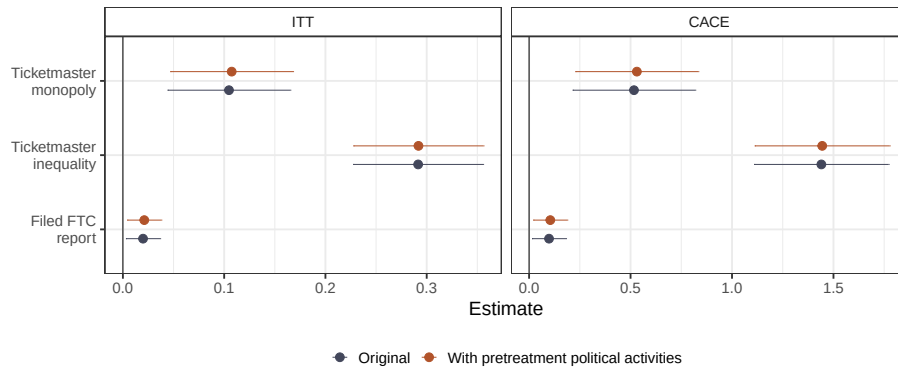
Table A8: CBPS Weight Summaries

Treatment	Mean	SD	Min.	Max.	ESS
November	1.99	0.51	1.18	5.19	4,097
November-August	1.98	1.13	1.02	11.63	4,000
Continuous	1.00	0.19	0.38	3.35	4,093

Note: Cell entries report summaries of weights estimated for each treatment variable using CBPS (Imai and Ratkovic 2014): means, standard deviations (SD), minimums, maximums, and the effective sample size (ESS). The unweighted sample size is 4,235.

To further mitigate confounding and improve precision, we include the covariates used in the CBPS weighting in the outcome models as well, as suggested in the literature on covariate adjustment in observational studies (e.g., Nguyen et al. 2017). However, results are not dependent on this choice. We use g-computation (Snowden et al. 2011) with our outcome models, which involves estimating average potential outcomes for the treated and control groups, then computing their differences to arrive at the treatment effect estimates. We report robust standard errors to account for uncertainty from the estimation of weights and treatment effects (Robins et al. 2000). Bootstrapping the entire process produces substantively identical results.

Figure A8: Estimated Treatment Effects Controlling for Pretreatment Political Activities



Note: The graphs present ITT (panel a) and CACE (panel b) estimates and 95% confidence intervals from the original specifications and after controlling for the count of pretreatment political activities.

A8 Covariate Balance

Here we assess covariate balance across all versions of our treatment variable to provide a comprehensive empirical assessment of the credibility of our identification strategy and research design. We evaluate balance in three categories of covariates: (1) measures of Swifties' fandom, (2) political variables, and (3) demographic variables.¹⁴ The balance metrics on which we focus are equivalence tests of covariate mean differences (Hartman and Hidalgo 2018), standardized mean differences (Greifer 2024a), Kolmogorov-Smirnov statistics (Greifer 2024a), and complement of overlap coefficients (Franklin et al. 2014).

A8.1 Equivalence Tests

Our first metric is the difference in covariate means between the treatment and control groups in natural units. Evidence in favor of the as-if randomness of treatment assignment strengthens to the extent that these differences are small, indicating balance across groups. We employ equivalence tests in this assessment. Rather than starting with the null hypothesis that a mean difference is zero, this approach begins with the perspective that the data are inconsistent with the research design (i.e., a non-zero difference in means). The test then seeks evidence in favor of the design, defined as a mean difference near zero. Structuring equivalence as the alternative hypothesis instead of the null greatly improves the credibility of the test (for a review, see Hartman and Hidalgo 2018).

A key decision the analyst must make to conduct equivalence tests is the establishment of an equivalence range, or set of values near zero within which the difference in covariate means would be considered equivalent in a practical sense. If the estimate and its 90% confidence interval fall within the equivalence range, the analyst can reject the null hypothesis of non-equivalence at the 0.05 level (see Lakens 2017). The size of the equivalence range can be informed by substantive knowledge, but generally represents a high-leverage researcher degree of freedom because it is straightforward to find the smallest range at which a covariate can “pass” the test. To remove ourselves from this issue to some degree, we use Hartman and Hidalgo's (2018) recommended range of $\pm 0.36\sigma$, where σ is the pooled standard deviation of the covariate.

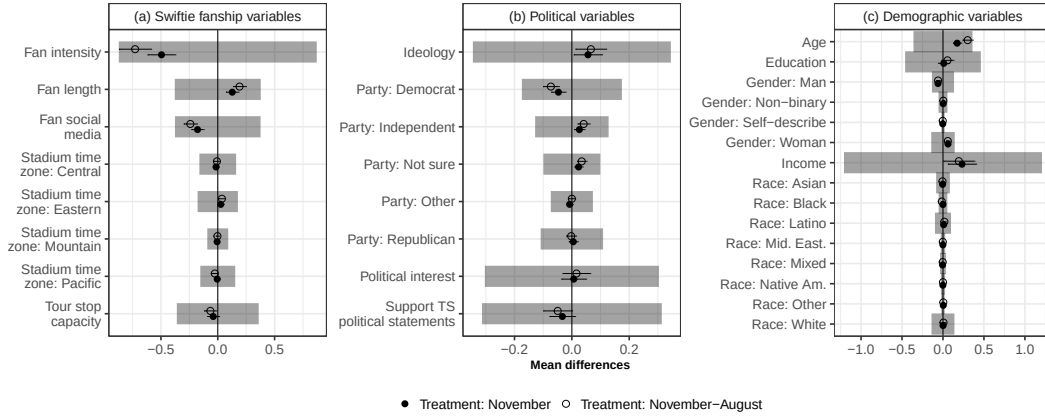
Figure A9 graphs mean differences of our covariates of interest (points), the associated 90% confidence intervals (line segments), and equivalence ranges (gray shading). Filled points represent the November treatment variable and open points represent the November-August treatment. The results indicate clear evidence of covariate balance. The points are generally close to zero and all fall within the shaded equivalence ranges. The confidence intervals essentially all fall within the ranges too, providing support for rejecting the null of non-equivalence at the 0.05 level.¹⁵ In short, the equivalence tests strongly support our claim that failure to secure primary-market tickets was a plausibly exogenous process.

Figures A10–A13 report balance results with and without our CBPS weights summarized in Section A7. Circles (triangles) represent the unweighted (weighted) statistics. Filled in (open) points represent the November (November-August) treatment. Smaller differences indicate stronger balance for all statistics reported. We consider a stricter balance criterion of 0.10 and a more relaxed criterion of 0.20. The results show that CBPS weighting effectively balances all of the covariates

¹⁴We also collected variables associated with the sale itself, but these measures are partially post-treatment. We use them in an assessment of treatment validity in Section A10.

¹⁵There are two edge cases to note. The lower confidence bound of the fan intensity estimate with the November-August treatment (open point, panel a) is just inside the equivalence range ($p = 0.046$). The upper confidence bound for the age estimate with the November-August treatment (open point, panel c) falls slightly outside the equivalence range ($p = 0.056$). As with traditional hypothesis tests, the criterion for statistical significance is somewhat arbitrary here. The general pattern in Figure A9 provides strong support for balance in these variables.

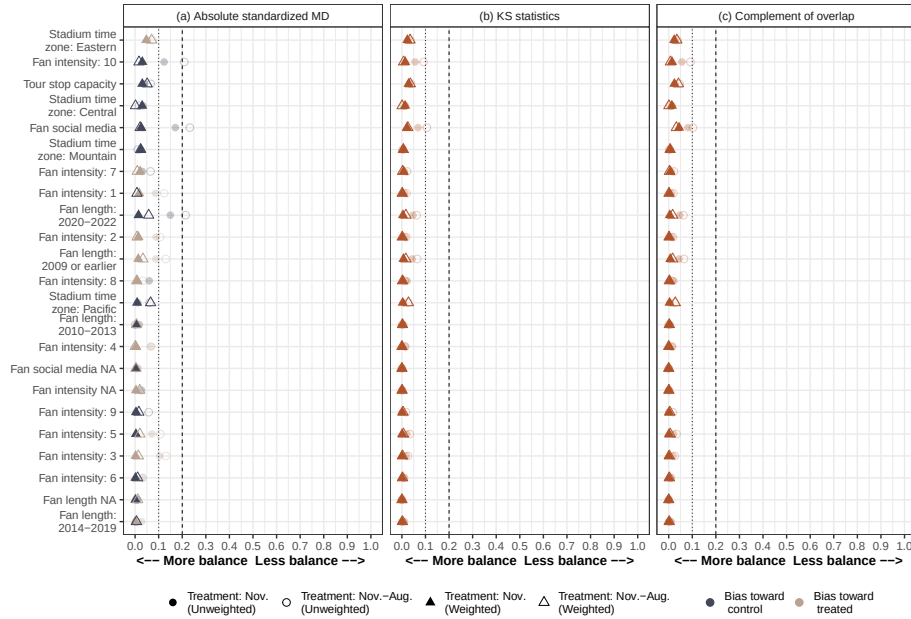
Figure A9: Unadjusted Equivalence Tests of Covariate Mean Differences



Note: The graphs report differences in covariate means by each binary treatment variable. Line segments indicate 90% confidence intervals and gray shading represents the equivalence range for each variable, computed as 0.36σ , where σ is the covariate standard deviation (see Hartman and Hidalgo 2018, 1006). Confidence intervals falling inside the equivalence range denote variables for which the equivalence test is passed at the 0.05 level. All variables are scaled in natural units except for tour stop capacity and age, which are standardized for ease of presentation.

at the level of the strict thresholds. Thus, employing the weights substantially enhances the causal leverage of our research design.

Figure A10: CBPS Adjusted Balance on Pretreatment Swiftie Fanship Variables

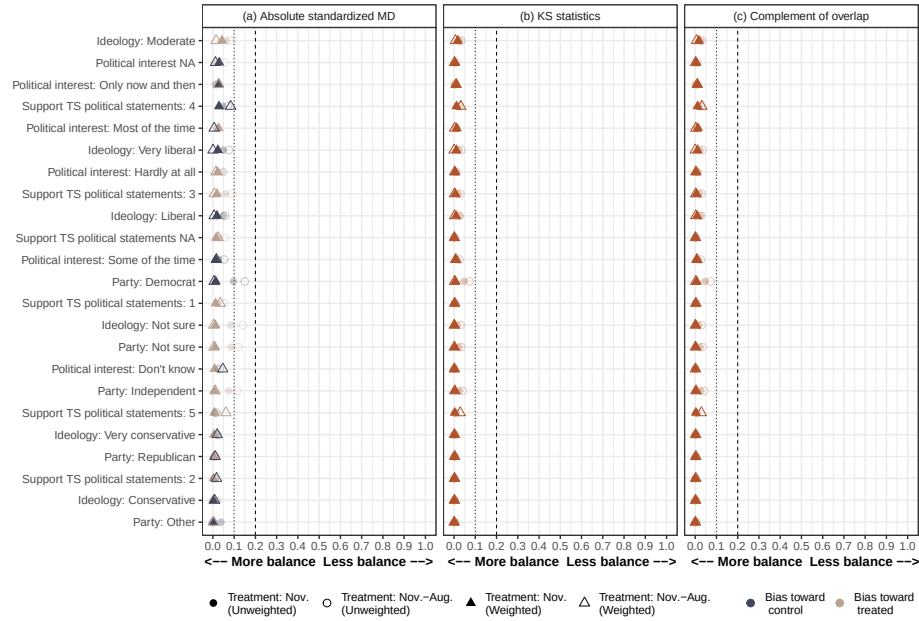


Note: The graphs report (a) absolute standardized mean differences, (b) Kolmogorov-Smirnov statistics, and (c) complement of overlap coefficients for variables related to pretreatment Swiftie fanship in the unadjusted and adjusted data. Smaller values indicate stronger balance for all three metrics. The dotted and dashed vertical lines denote common balance thresholds of 0.10 and 0.20, respectively.

A9 CACE Estimator Justification

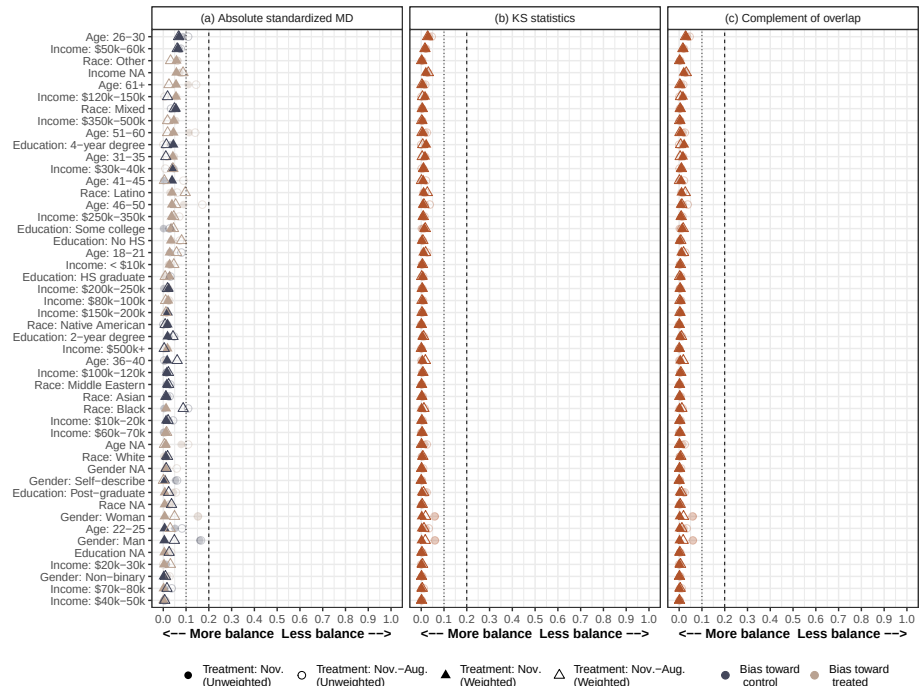
In the main text we report complier average causal effects (CACE), which require a slightly different definition of treatment than our intent-to-treat (ITT) analysis. The ITT estimates represent the effect of failing to secure primary-market tickets on our outcome variables. In estimating the CACE, we define treatment as failure to attend any shows in 2023 and failure to secure tickets to a 2024 show. Thus, the CACE can be interpreted as the effects among Swifties for whom securing primary-market tickets was determinative for attending a show. These estimates come from instrumental variable

Figure A11: CBPS Adjusted Balance on Political Variables



Note: The graphs report (a) absolute standardized mean differences, (b) Kolmogorov-Smirnov statistics, and (c) complement of overlap coefficients for political variables in the unadjusted and adjusted data. Smaller values indicate stronger balance for all three metrics. The dotted and dashed vertical lines denote balance thresholds of 0.10 and 0.20, respectively.

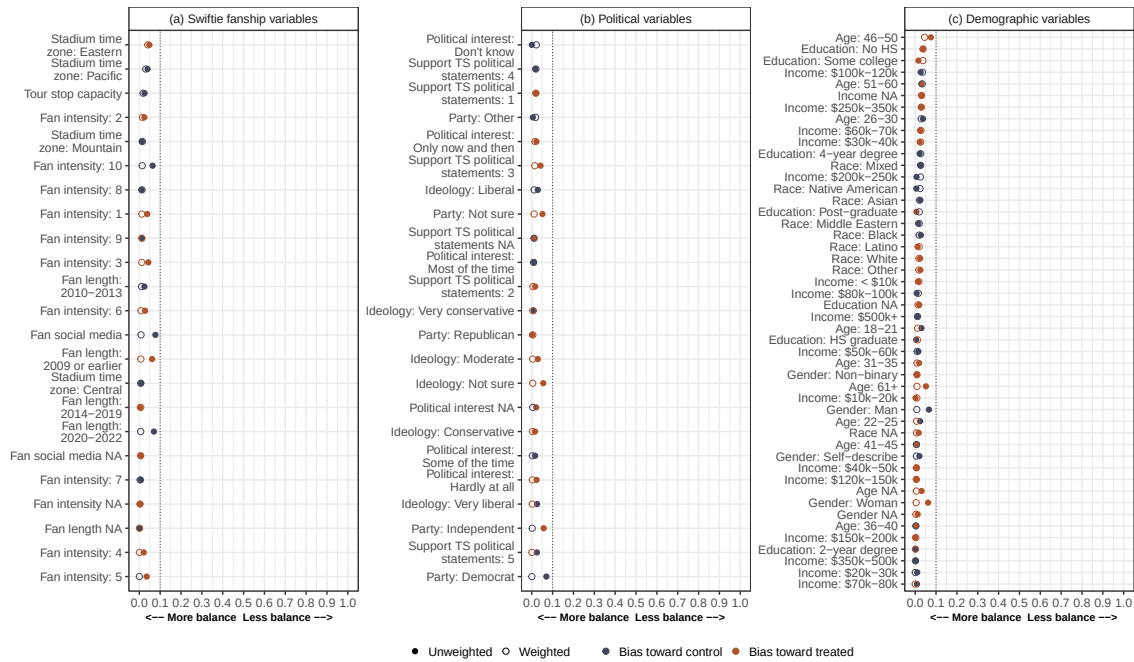
Figure A12: CBPS Adjusted Balance on Demographic Variables



Note: The graphs report (a) absolute standardized mean differences, (b) Kolmogorov-Smirnov statistics, and (c) complement of overlap coefficients for demographic variables in the unadjusted and adjusted data. Smaller values indicate stronger balance for all three metrics. The dotted and dashed vertical lines denote balance thresholds of 0.10 and 0.20, respectively.

(IV) models estimated via two-stage least squares (2SLS) with our balancing weights. Specifically, our November treatment is used in 2SLS models as an instrument for an indicator of failure to attend any shows in 2023 and secure tickets to a 2024

Figure A13: CBPS Adjusted Balance on the Continuous Treatment Variable (Failures/Attempts)



Note: The graphs report correlations between the covariates and the continuous treatment variable (the proportion of primary-market ticket attempts that were failures) in the unadjusted and adjusted data. Smaller values indicate stronger balance. The dotted vertical lines denote a balance threshold of 0.10.

show. Variation in this latter treatment variable is comprised of (1) as-if random assignment from post-November primary-market ticket opportunities *and* (2) non-random selection into secondary-market ticket purchasing and show attendance. IV analyses require justification of key assumptions: exogeneity, relevance, monotonicity, and the exclusion restriction (e.g., Sovey and Green 2011).

A9.1 Exogeneity

First, the IV estimator assumes that the instrument—here, the November treatment indicator from the ITT analyses—is unrelated to unmeasured variables associated with the outcome. This assumption holds to the extent that our proposed natural experiment is justified. Our preanalysis plan and main text make the case for the as-if random nature of the November ticket presales results, including the true lotteries administered by Ticketmaster and the haphazard nature of errors in the ticket-buying process. We also show in Section A8 that the data display strong covariate balance across this variable, with or without weighting adjustment. In short, there is substantial evidence for the exogeneity of the instrument.

A9.2 Relevance

IV also requires that the instrument strongly predicts the endogenous treatment variable after controlling for covariates. Figure A14 graphs the residualized instrument (x-axis) against the residualized treatment (y-axis) after controlling for our main set of covariates in the full sample. The blue line is a linear fit with a slope coefficient of 0.197, indicating a positive relationship, as expected by the relevance assumption.

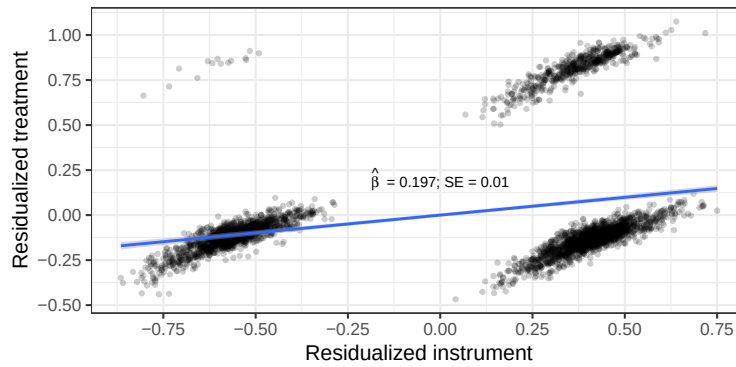
Olea and Pflueger (2013) propose a formal test for weak instruments that is robust to numerous regression violations. Their “effective F” test statistic is the first-stage regression’s F-statistic scaled by its variance-covariance matrix. Lal et al. (2024) suggest that values greater than 10 indicate a strong instrument (see also Olea and Pflueger 2013). Across the various outcomes considered here, the effective F statistics range from 511 to 538. In short, we find strong evidence that the instrument is relevant.

A9.3 Monotonicity

Monotonicity requires plausibility in the assertion that there are no defiers in the population and sample—cases that receive the treatment (control) if and only if they are assigned to the control (treatment) group (Sovey and Green 2011). In this context, defiers would be Swifties who satisfy *both* of the following conditions:

1. Would *not* attend any show in 2023 and would not secure tickets for 2024 if they secured primary-market tickets in November 2022;

Figure A14: Instrument Relevance with Partialled Out Covariates



Note: The graph presents the residualized instrument (x-axis) against the residualized treatment (y-axis) after controlling for our main set of covariates. The blue line is a linear fit and shading indicates its 95% confidence interval.

2. Would attend a show in 2023 and/or would secure tickets for 2024 if they did *not* secure primary-market tickets in November 2022.

In other words, this group receives the treatment opposite of their assignment status. But because we only see one realization of the instrument and the treatment for each person, we cannot identify this group in our sample. The data include 14 respondents who satisfy the first condition and 1,920 who satisfy the second.¹⁶ However, to be classified as defiers these Swifties would also need to follow the opposite of their assignment if their November ticket presales status (counterfactually) changed. If that condition did not occur, the first group would simply be always-takers and the second would be never-takers (Sovey and Green 2011, 193).

We contend that it is reasonable to assume no defiers in this population. Given the effort and expense associated with attempting to purchase tickets to The Eras Tour and Swifties' strong interest in attending, we believe it is unlikely anyone would satisfy *both* of the above conditions. The very small number of people in the first group—who did not go to a show despite buying primary-market tickets—more likely experienced changes to their plans or availability rather than displayed a commitment to act opposite of what their ticket-buying fate implied.¹⁷ And the second group—Swifties who attended a show despite failing to secure primary-market tickets in November 2022—was clearly motivated to attend the tour at all costs. These fans either kept trying to get primary-market tickets or resorted to the secondary market. Given that they undertook additional effort and expense to secure tickets, it seems indefensible that these Swifties would have also decided not to attend a show had they been successful in November 2022.

A9.4 Exclusion Restriction

Finally, the exclusion restriction assumes that the instrument affects the outcome *only* through its effect on the treatment. That is, whether or not Swifties got completely shut out from the tour affected the outcome variables; their individual experiences with Ticketmaster did not matter independent of their choice to purchase tickets or not after November 2022. The assumption could be violated if, for example, fans who failed to secure primary-market tickets opted to purchase secondary-market tickets *and* changed their political engagement or attitudes *based on their November 2022 Ticketmaster experience*. We view this scenario as much less plausible compared to the scenario in which these Swifties' attitudes changed because they were forced to pay a large premium for tickets due to their as-if random failure to secure primary-market tickets in the November presales. The motivation to participate in the ticket sale was to attend a show; the ticket itself was simply a means to that end. Thus, we contend that, given the modified definition of treatment noted above, the ticket-buying experience itself did not exert an effect on Swifties' attitudes and behavior beyond its implications for their ability to attend a show.

A10 Empirical Treatment Validity Check

Our main conceptual definition of treatment status is failure to secure primary-market tickets in the Ticketmaster presales. We claim that the unpredictable nature of timing and errors experienced during the sales produced randomness in treatment assignment. Several survey questions allow us to empirically check this connection between errors and treatment status.

¹⁶An additional 10 respondents secured primary-market tickets after November 2022, but then did not attend a show. This group of 10 and the 14 who satisfy the first condition represent the 24 respondents who moved from control to treated in the fourth phase depicted in Figure 4.

¹⁷Our results are substantively identical if we remove these 14 respondents from the estimation sample. The same is true if we omit the full group of 24 control-to-treatment movers discussed in footnote 16, which includes the 14 mentioned previously (see Figure 4).

Table A9: Ticketmaster Day-of-Sale Correlates of Treatment Status

	Outcome: Failed to secure primary-market tickets							
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Total website errors	0.109* (0.008)							0.118* (0.009)
Virtual queue: 1-3 hours		0.113* (0.031)						0.089* (0.030)
Virtual queue: 3-4 hours		0.135* (0.033)						0.089* (0.034)
Virtual queue: 4-7 hours		0.148* (0.031)						0.046 (0.031)
Virtual queue: 7+ hours		0.204* (0.034)						0.048 (0.036)
Stadium used SeatGeek			-0.087* (0.024)					-0.038 (0.024)
Presale prep: 1-2 hours				-0.076* (0.024)				-0.066* (0.024)
Presale prep: 3-4 hours				-0.082* (0.028)				-0.042 (0.029)
Presale prep: 4+ hours				0.024 (0.028)				0.011 (0.029)
Total Verified Fan codes					-0.051* (0.006)			-0.046* (0.006)
Total boosts						-0.106* (0.013)		-0.086* (0.014)
Friends with ticket failure							0.002 (0.001)	-0.0001 (0.001)
Intercept	0.187* (0.013)	0.213* (0.025)	0.360* (0.010)	0.384* (0.019)	0.446* (0.015)	0.417* (0.013)	0.334* (0.013)	0.299* (0.031)
N	2,676	2,675	2,676	2,676	2,622	2,676	2,497	2,474
Adjusted R ²	0.065	0.011	0.004	0.008	0.040	0.023	0.001	0.132

Note: Cell entries report linear probability model coefficients and robust standard errors (in parentheses). The outcome is treatment status from the November 2022 Ticketmaster presales. The sample only includes respondents who (1) were not waitlisted by Ticketmaster or (2) participated in the Capital One presale on November 16. * p < 0.05.

Specifically, we asked respondents about the number and type of errors they experienced on the Ticketmaster website, the amount of time they spent in the virtual queue, the amount of time they spent preparing for the sale, the number of Verified Fan codes and boosts that they had in the sale, and the number of friends they knew who were unable to secure primary-market tickets. We also include a control for ticketing platform, because two stadiums used SeatGeek instead of Ticketmaster for the sales.¹⁸

Table A9 reports estimates from linear probability models of treatment status (November treatment) as a function of these day-of-sale variables. They are partially post-treatment variables because they were realized only after Ticketmaster's Verified Fan lottery on November 14. Thus, they were only relevant for Swifties who attempted to purchase tickets in the sales on November 15-16. The estimation sample for the models in Table A9 includes respondents who (1) were not waitlisted by Ticketmaster or (2) participated in the Capital One sale on November 16.¹⁹

The estimates indicate that these day-of-sale factors contributed to treatment assignment as predicted. The positive coefficients on total website errors—which ranges 0-5—indicate that each additional error experienced by a user was associated with approximately 11-12 percentage point increases in the probability of failure to secure tickets. Compared to the reference category of less than one hour in the virtual queue, longer wait times were also predictive of ticket failure. The estimates for presale prep time in model (4) suggest that preparation reduced Swifties' chances of ticket failure, but this pattern weakens in model (8) with the other variables included. Respondents with more Verified Fan codes (sample maximum: 20) and more boosts (maximum of two) were less likely to experience ticket failure. Friends with ticket failure and the SeatGeek indicator are essentially uncorrelated with ticket purchasing success after controlling for other factors.

These results provide empirical validation of the treatment assignment process described in our preanalysis plan and the main text. When Swifties were on the Ticketmaster website during the sales, their ticket-buying fates were determined by errors and waiting in the virtual queue. Verified Fan codes and boosts gave them partial ability to overcome the website problems. But these factors did not guarantee success and, most importantly, they are explained by existing pretreatment

¹⁸SeatGeek sold primary-market tickets for shows at State Farm Stadium in Glendale, Arizona and AT&T Stadium in Arlington, Texas. However, Ticketmaster administered the lotteries for Verified Fan codes for these shows and the same set of problems that plagued Ticketmaster sales hampered SeatGeek buyers as well.

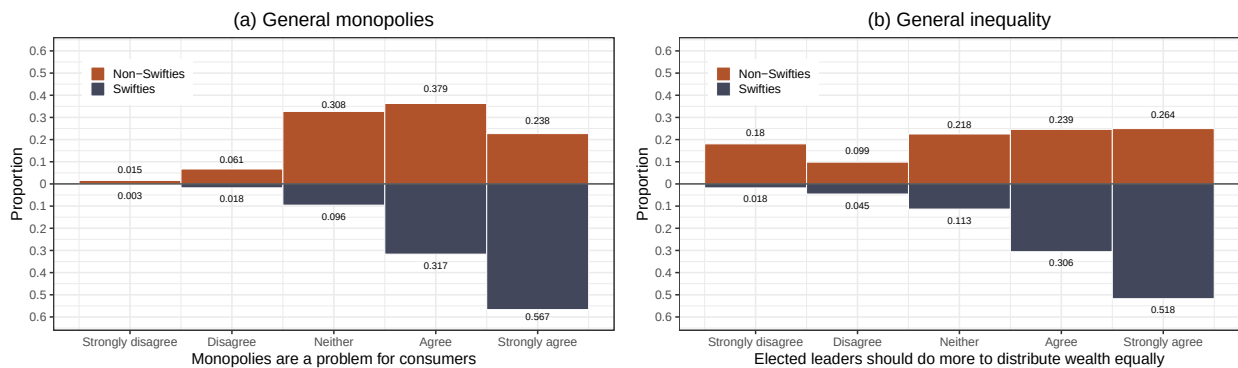
¹⁹Capital One cardholders were able to bypass the November 14 lottery, but still faced the randomness of the sale itself (see Figure A1).

covariates in our data: fan intensity, fan length, and fan social media use.²⁰ Thus, we do not view these day-of-sale variables as threats to our inferences. Instead, they support the internal validity of our conceptualization of treatment status.

A11 Outcome Variable Comparison to the American Public

How do Swifties’ views on economic fairness compare to the American public in general? Here we consider descriptive differences on two of our outcome variables between Swifties and members of the public who are not Taylor Swift fans. We fielded our two outcome variables that did not reference Ticketmaster—attitudes toward monopolies and inequality in general—on a 1,000-respondent module embedded in the 2023 Cooperative Election Study (CES).²¹ This survey was administered in late 2023, shortly after our own study.²² We filtered out those who reported attempts at purchasing tickets to The Eras Tour, leaving us with a sample of 893 “Non-Swiftie” respondents.²³ Figure A15 graphs the distribution of the two outcome variables for this group (orange) and our sample of Swifties (blue). The CES data are weighted to represent a national sample of American adults.

Figure A15: Comparison of General Outcome Variable Distributions in Swiftie and Non-Swiftie Samples



Note: The graphs present the distributions of the general versions of the outcome variables—monopolies in panel (a) and inequality in panel (b)—for our Swiftie sample ($n = 4,235$) and non-Swiftie respondents from the Cooperative Election Study (CES) in 2023 ($n = 893$). The CES data are weighted to represent a national sample of American adults.

The graphs demonstrate that Swifties’ attitudes toward monopolies (panel a) and inequality (panel b) are noticeably different from the general American public. Swifties as a group are much more likely to agree that monopolies in general are a problem for consumers and that elected officials should do more to distribute wealth equally. These findings are not surprising given that agreement with these statements reflects a left-leaning perspective and Swifties are disproportionately liberal and identify with the Democratic Party (see Table A1). Most importantly, the results do not present a problem for our inferences; in studying an issue public, we would not expect the membership to constitute a representative sample of the public as a whole. In fact, if anything the compressed variation on Swifties’ attitudes toward monopolies and inequality suggests that our research design provides a difficult test for detecting effects within the population.²⁴

A12 Legislative Action on the Event Ticket Industry

In Section 7 of the main text we consider governmental responsiveness on event ticketing. This section provides more details on our descriptive analysis of event ticket industry bill introductions in state legislatures and Congress over time.

A12.1 Search Process

We searched for bills using the legislative tracking service LegiScan. This service allows for keyword searches of bill texts and titles in the states and Congress in real time through a web or programming interface. We iterated through several search approaches to minimize false positive and false negative hits, eventually arriving at a sample of 172 bills introduced during the period 2009–2023. The main search string we used to produce this sample is listed below:

²⁰In additional regression models (not shown), we find that these Swiftie fandom variables are statistically significant correlates of total Verified Fan codes and total boosts.

²¹Question wording and response options were identical between our Swiftie survey and the CES survey. We did not ask the Ticketmaster-specific questions because the non-Swiftie respondents would have lacked the context of the Swiftie respondents when answering.

²²YouGov fielded the survey from November 8 to December 10. See Ansolabehere et al. (2019) for complete details on the CES survey methodology.

²³Specifically, these respondents are not members of the potential issue public as defined in our study because they did not attempt to purchase tickets.

²⁴In the main text we report negligible treatment effects on these particular outcome variables. However, we do find meaningful treatment effects on the Ticketmaster-specific outcomes, which also display the pattern of strong agreement shown among Swifties in Figure A15.

“Ticketmaster” or “Live Nation” or “ticket issuer” or “ticket resale” or “ticket resell” or “ticket industry” or “sale of event tickets”

Our raw data included 301 hits. We read the title and bill summary of each of these bills to determine if it was, in fact, a unique event ticket bill. This process uncovered some duplicate bills that were re-introduced within the same chamber; in those cases, we only kept one bill. However, we allowed similar bills introduced in the upper and lower chambers to count as two unique bills.²⁵ Additionally, we found some bills that, despite including these terms, were not directly related to the event ticket industry.²⁶

A13 A Brief History of the Event Ticket Issue Public

This research presents a case study of individuals joining a pre-existing issue public. Indeed, Swifties were not the first group of fans to recognize and form political attitudes due to problems with Ticketmaster. The event ticket issue public most likely began with grunge band fans in the early 1990s, especially fans of Seattle-based Pearl Jam. As Boehlert (1995) describes, there was minimal fan protest over ticketing issues in the 1980s. Consumers allowed major live acts such as The Eagles, Rod Stewart, and others to continually set records for ticket prices. But in the 1990s several artists began to reverse that trend, seeking to become the most fan-friendly experience with respect to price. Ticketmaster’s service fees were a constant roadblock to this effort, leading to fan frustration and negotiations between band managers and Ticketmaster. Pearl Jam exemplified this tension. Not only did some of its fans take legal action against Ticketmaster, but the band itself pursued several avenues toward resolution. Band members Jeff Ament and Stone Gossard testified before Congress in June 1994 and the group famously boycotted Ticketmaster and the venues it controlled for a period of time.²⁷

Another key element of the history of this issue public is Ticketmaster’s path to market dominance (see Gastelum 2024 for a detailed discussion). The company formed in the late 1970s and quickly became a major player in the ticketing industry by the 1990s. In 1991 Ticketmaster acquired its major competitor, Ticketron. Ten years later, it entered into a six-year agreement with Clear Channel Entertainment—an event promotion company—to provide ticketing for all of its events. Clear Channel became Live Nation in 2005 and when the agreement ended soon after, Live Nation announced plans to manage its own ticketing operations. This period of time, beginning in 2007, led to a brief window in which the prospect of true market competition emerging to the benefit of fans appeared to be forthcoming. Instead, Ticketmaster and Live Nation merged in 2010, giving Ticketmaster control of more than 80% of the market in the U.S. alone. This deal renewed consumer frustration over the ever-increasing costs of event tickets during the 2010s (Fruits et al. 2024).

The COVID-19 pandemic led to a substantial decline in interest in the issue because live acts were canceled due to social distancing restrictions. Thus, there was considerable pent-up demand from consumers by the end of 2022, when The Eras Tour was announced (Noah 2023). In addition, two other major acts toured in 2023: Bruce Springsteen and the E Street Band and Beyoncé. Ticketmaster managed both tours’ ticketing and employed Verified Fan presale lotteries, as with The Eras Tour. Additionally, both tours produced fan backlash due to ticketing problems. Springsteen fans’ primary concern was ticket prices; they were able to access seats on Ticketmaster’s website, but were unhappy with Springsteen’s choice to price tickets at full market value for the first time in his career (Shanfield 2022). In the case of Beyoncé, demand was very high, limiting supply. It was possible to buy primary-market tickets to her “Renaissance World Tour” after the Verified Fan presales, but pricing and seat quality were major concerns (McKenzie 2023).

A13.1 Empirical Uniqueness of Ticketing for The Eras Tour

These events highlight the unique advantage of utilizing the case of Swifties and The Eras Tour to test our theory. We contend that the same theoretical process we describe could have motivated fans of Springsteen or Beyoncé to move from the potential issue public to the issue public. But the circumstances of those artists’ tours would create non-ignorable selection into treatment if applied to our case. First, Swifties’ primary concern was buying *any* tickets, with price as a secondary problem. This feature produced a clear, binary distinction between Swifties (secured tickets or not). Additionally, primary-market tickets were never available to the general public after the Verified Fan presales.²⁸ If they had been available, the presale lotteries would have lost predictive power over whether a fan attended a show, deteriorating our causal leverage. Demand at the presale stage was so high that it exhausted supply, preserving the as-if random nature of ticket distribution.

²⁵For example, the BOSS and SWIFT Act of 2023 was introduced in the U.S. House in May 2023 (HB3660) and another version was introduced in the Senate in September 2023 (SB2957). We include both HB3660 and SB2957 in our count of bills for the U.S. Congress in 2023.

²⁶For instance, legislation outlawing “vaccine passports” was fairly common in Republican-controlled state legislatures during the COVID-19 pandemic. Some of these bills explicitly banned event organizers from requiring vaccination for entry into ticketed events.

²⁷This strategy reduced the band’s access to major markets, among other problems. Pearl Jam ultimately returned to Ticketmaster, to the disappointment of many fans. Ironically, the group’s 2024 “Dark Matter World Tour” included a Verified Fan lottery—the same mechanism that animated our natural experiment on Swifties.

²⁸As we describe in the main text and this document, the ticket drops that occurred after the presales were themselves dominated by randomness.

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